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Brand Personification Continuum

A Growth-Sensitive Diagnostic Stage Model for Organizational Growth and Representational Complexity

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Brand Personification Continuum - A Growth-Sensitive Diagnostic Stage Model for Organizational Growth and Representational Complexity

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Abstract

Background
While previous research has examined brand personality and personification and how it manifests in start-ups, SMEs, and corporations, limited attention has been given to how brand personification changes as organizations grow. Existing literature also lacks conceptual clarity regarding how different organizational actors and stakeholders contribute to brand personification across growth stages.

Purpose
The purpose of this study is to reconceptualize brand personification as a dynamic and evolving process shaped by organizational growth. More specifically, the study aims to develop a diagnostic brand personification continuum that explains how the sources, coordination, and complexity of brand personification change as organizations expand and involve a broader range of internal and external stakeholders.

Method
To fulfil the exploratory purpose of this thesis, a qualitative research design was applied. Data were collected through 12 purposefully selected semi-structured interviews with industry professionals covering all three conceptual stages. The data were thematically analysed and coded through five literature-informed constructs in an iterative process. This movement between theory and empirical material was grounded in a deductive research approach, within a social constructivist ontological stance.

Conclusion
The study concludes that brand personification changes in type, source, and governance logic as organizations grow. In the Concentration stage, brand personification is mainly founder-driven and expressed through the founder's identity, communication, and direct interactions. In the Distribution stage, personification becomes increasingly shared across employees and internal systems, requiring clearer alignment, codification, and repeatable brand narratives. In the Dispersion stage, personification extends across representatives, characters, users, communities, and external stakeholders, many of whom operate beyond the organization's direct control. Therefore, brand personification should be understood as a stage-sensitive and diagnostic process rather than a fixed personality profile or isolated communication tactic. The Brand Personification Continuum offers a practical framework for identifying where personification is located, how it is coordinated, and what forms of governance are needed as representational complexity increases.

Declaration of AI usage

We hereby declare that this thesis represents our own work.

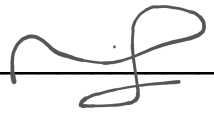
We declare that we have obtained the necessary ethical approval (e.g., GDPR) and acknowledged my/our obligations and the rights of the participants/respondents in the research.

We have read and applied the Jönköping University's current research ethics guidelines with regards to the use of artificial intelligence (AI) tools in this work as presented in the Course Guide. During the preparation of this work the authors used the following AI tools and the purpose for their use.

Generative AI programs utilizing Large Language Models, in particular ChatGPT 5.5 and Claude AI, were critically used in this paper to;

- Improve grammar and wording,
- Assist in shortening or elongations of paragraphs,
- Help analyze and allocate themes from transcripts,
- Further assist in the search for academic articles through "deep research" (in order to find information that might have been missed through manual search).

As authors, we have reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the thesis.

Signature:  Signature: 

Date: _____ Date: _____

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1. Introduction

1.1. Background

People across cultures and ages tend to instinctively describe non-human things in human terms to make them easier to understand (Fielden-Burns & Piquer-Píriz, 2022). Likewise, brands are now widely seen as social constructs created by marketers and consumers (Muñiz and O'Guinn, 2001), implying that brands are "social products" that consumers use to co-create, communicate and maintain their identities (Belk, 2013). In practice, companies frequently imbue their brands with human characteristics and personality traits so that marketing messages feel more personal and relatable, in a process called brand personification (Cohen, 2014; Harrison & Kwon, 2023).

Brand personification, which is the focal concept of this study, refers to the metaphorical embodiment of a brand's personality and image (Davies et al., 2001). The justification lies in the fact that people form bonds and loyalties more easily with other people than with abstract objects (Cohen, 2014; Fielden-Burns & Piquer-Píriz, 2022). Consequently, personifying a brand provides a familiar "face" that helps consumers interpret its intentions and character, an effect that has been observed in digital media (Chen et al., 2015; Harrison & Kwon, 2023; Brandão & Popoli, 2023; Ghorbani et al., 2022). When consumers feel that a brand is personable and human-like, they often relate to it similarly to how they relate to people (Fournier & Alvarez, 2012; MacInnis & Folkes, 2017; Harrison & Kwon, 2023).

At the same time, contemporary social theory reminds us that identities, whether individual or corporate, are fluid rather than fixed (Bauman, 2000). Brands today therefore operate in a fluid identity environment where technological and cultural shifts can quickly change how a brand is seen (Hewer, 2022). This underscores the importance of integrating psychological and sociological perspectives when studying brand anthropomorphism and consumer-brand relationships (Roy & Banerjee, 2025; Sharma & Rahman, 2022; Swaminathan et al., 2020). In particular, it suggests that we should examine the mechanisms by which consumers come to anthropomorphize or personify brands, not just assume that it happens automatically.

Similarly, rather than growing in a purely linear or continuous predictive manner, organizations tend to move through identifiable phases in which internal structures, decision-making processes, and external relationships change in systematic ways (Galbraith, 1982; McMahon, 1998). While it is known that the size and subsequent capabilities affect a firm's ability to invest their resources in the marketing and branding departments (Yönel et al., 2026; Juntunen, 2025; Chaudhri et al., 2022; Eggers et al., 2016), less is known how their current organizational stage affects their brand personification. As brand personification is context-sensitive (Fielden-Burns & Piquer-Píriz, 2022; Aguirre-Rodriguez, 2013), it is highly relevant to examine this dynamic in relation to the scale of the company through the lens of an organizational continuum. In doing so, it is possible to develop a diagnostic tool, in which companies are able to understand where

they find themselves within it and make sound decisions and moves accordingly (cf. McMahon, 1998).

1.2. Problem discussion

Based on gaps in previous research, it is possible to obtain an approach for this study, which contributes to existing research and paves the way for future research (Bell et al., 2022, p. 4). While research on branding, brand personality, and brand personification has grown substantially, important gaps still remain. Existing studies often examine branding within isolated concepts such as brand identity and brand personality. Thus, concurrent literature has usually entailed examining the impact of founder personality (Shi, 2019; Ji et al., 2022; McCarthy et al., 2023) and corporate brand personality (Keller & Richey, 2006; Rekom et al., 2006; Raffelt et al., 2013; Gorbaniuk et al., 2017). In a similar manner, there are studies discussing startup brand personification (Ji et al., 2022), SME brand personification (Centeno et al., 2019) and corporate brand personification (Davies et al., 2001; Fetscherin & Usunier, 2012; Aguirre-Rodriguez, 2013). However, there seems to be little research examining how organizational scale affects brand personality or personification.

At the same time, the concepts of brand personality and brand personification are used inconsistently in the literature (Cohen, 2014; Roy & Banerjee, 2025). Some studies treat personification broadly as anthropomorphic branding, while others define it as specific communication tactics. This conceptual ambiguity makes it difficult to understand how personification changes across stages of organizational growth. Current research also lacks a diagnostic logic explaining when personification is primarily founder-driven, internally coordinated, or distributed across stakeholder networks (Sharma & Rahman, 2022; Astner & Gaddefors, 2025).

A recurring call in the literature concerns the need to understand how brands evolve over time as ventures move from early-stage formation to scaling and organizational expansion (Eggers et al., 2016; Yönel et al., 2026; Chaudhri et al., 2022). While existing studies acknowledge that brand identity is fluid in the early stages, there is limited understanding of how founder-centered branding transitions into more distributed forms of brand representation as organizations grow (Astner & Gaddefors, 2025).

Beyond the founder, the role of internal stakeholders also remains underexplored. Research shows that employees influence customer perceptions and brand equity, especially through service interactions and internal branding practices (King & Grace, 2010; Sirianni et al., 2013; Braxton & Lau-Gesk, 2020). However, broader questions regarding internal brand governance, employee alignment, and organizational coordination remain insufficiently examined (King & Grace, 2008; Scheffer & Crystal, 2008; Zeitoun et al., 2020; Boukis et al., 2021; Juntunen, 2025).

In parallel, several branches of literature suggest that brand meaning and image are increasingly shaped by multiple organizational actors and stakeholders, including users (Xie et al., 2020; Yang et al., 2023), employees (King & Grace, 2010; Boukis et al., 2021), executives (Fleck et al., 2014; Zeitoun et al., 2020), and online communities (Swaminathan et al., 2020; Ghorbani et al., 2022). However, these streams remain fragmented rather than integrated into a broader understanding of how different actors collectively influence brand personification, and how these sources interact across organizational growth stages.

This study addresses these gaps by developing a diagnostic brand personification continuum that examines how brand personification evolves across stages of organizational growth. The notion of a continuum has been used in other fields, particularly in healthcare research, where the “continuum of care” describes how different actors and interventions contribute to outcomes across sequential stages of a patients' health process (McBride-Foster & Allen, 2007). Although the context in this study differs, the underlying logic that complex phenomena unfold across interconnected stages rather than isolated events provides a useful analogy for understanding how brand personification mechanisms evolve as organizations grow (cf. Chan et al., 2021). Thus, rather than treating brand personification as static, the study conceptualizes it as a dynamic and context-dependent process shaped by organizational scale, internal coordination, and stakeholder involvement.

1.3. Purpose

The purpose of this study is to reconceptualize brand personification as a dynamic, diagnostic, and relational continuum that evolves alongside organisational growth. The aim is therefore to explore and explain how the sources and coordination of brand personification change as representational complexity increases.

1.4. Research Question

This leads us to the research question being assessed in our study:

How does brand personification change across organisational growth stages as representational complexity increases?

2. Literature review

2.1. Approach to the literature review

To get a more comprehensive understanding of the field being researched, a literature review was conducted to synthesize and analyze existing research on brand personification and organizational growth (Snyder, 2019; Kraus et al., 2022; Daymon & Holloway, 2011, pp. 40-41). By collecting and examining a range of relevant research articles, it becomes possible to identify similarities, differences, and recurring themes within the literature (Bell et al., 2022, p. 93). This positions the study within the broader body of existing research and helps advance theory (Kraus et al., 2022; Post et al., 2020).

The literature review conducted for this study can be classified as a narrative review. Rather than applying rigid procedures for selecting and analysing studies, narrative reviews allow the researcher to synthesize findings, identify patterns and theoretical relationships, and develop new perspectives in the chosen research field (Baumeister & Leary, 1997). This approach suits the study's interpretivistic epistemological stance, especially when taking into account the fragmented and emerging nature of the field (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 98-99; Juntunen & Lehenkari, 2021). Consequently, the review helps build a clearer theoretical foundation for the subsequent analysis within the thesis.

The review process was iterative, allowing the researchers to refine the research focus throughout the writing process (Juntunen & Lehenkari, 2021). This allowed the theoretical framework to develop through continued engagement with the literature and constructive peer-led feedback. Details regarding the article selection process, search terms, databases, inclusion and exclusion criteria, along with source criticism are presented in Appendices A and B.

2.2. Brand personality

During the 1990s, the concept that brands could have a personality gained traction. Jennifer Aaker (1997) famously defined brand personality as "*the set of human characteristics associated with a brand*." In other words, brand personality is the *abstract bundle of traits that consumers attribute to a brand*. David Aaker (2010) later extends this by arguing that brand personality acts as "*the glue*" that holds together a brand's identity and communications. Thus, two companies selling what at face value is essentially the same product can distinguish themselves by strategically projecting different personalities onto their brands.

Aaker (1997) and Aaker (2010) also distinguish brand personality from human personality: whereas a person's personality emerges psychologically from intrinsic traits and attributes, a

brand's personality is deliberately constructed. For brands, personalities are contextually shaped by creators, managers, endorsers, marketing messages, symbolic cues, consumer experiences, and market forces (Aaker, 1997). As a result, brand personality research originally relied on projective techniques rather than on attributing personality to a concrete individual.

Azoulay and Kapferer (2003) later critiqued early models by pointing out that some included attributes, like skills or social roles, that are not "true" personality traits in the psychological sense. They proposed instead that brand personality measures should be restricted to actual psychological traits that are "both applicable to and relevant for brands" (Azoulay and Kapferer, 2003, p. 151).

2.3. Brand personification

Brand personification is the metaphorical representation of a brand, its reputation and personality (Davies et al., 2001). A central element of this concept is its social dimension. In particular, anthropomorphism, i.e. the tendency for individuals to perceive non-human entities as having human traits, plays an important role in how brands are interpreted and experienced. Through this process, consumers may interact with brands in ways that resemble interpersonal relationships. Brand personification is therefore closely linked to the sociological perspective of branding and parasocial consumer-brand relationships (Fournier & Alvarez, 2012; Huang & Mitchell, 2014).

Cohen (2014) defines brand personification generally as "*the use by a brand of a character with human-like characteristics in* […] *marketing-related purposes*" (Cohen, 2014, p. 3). In his taxonomy, Cohen identifies five personification strategies or "carriers"; a character who embodies the brand itself, a character who serves as a spokesperson, a character who is an ambassador, a brand mascot, and any other character tied to the brand. These strategies lie on a continuum from fully fictional characters to real humans serving as the brand's "face", from which brand meaning is materialized.

Brand personification research is especially relevant in a digital age, as much of existing brand personality research is rooted in understanding the dynamics of "offline" brands (Ghorbani et al., 2022). Today, brands operate heavily through digital platforms and social media, signified by interactive, real-time dialogue and communication (Harrison & Kwon, 2023; Ghorbani et al., 2022). Studies show that when brands adopt a casual, conversational tone on social media, consumers experience a greater sense of social presence and are more likely to engage with the brand (Jeong et al., 2022; Barcelos et al., 2018). Similarly, Harrison and Kwon (2023) find that when brands respond promptly and personably to real-time events on platforms like Twitter (now X), consumers perceive the brand as more relatable and trust-building interactions occur. Consequently, digital platforms allow brands to enact personification in new ways and alter how brand personalities are formed and perceived online (Ghorbani et al., 2022; Jeong et al., 2022; Barcelos et al., 2018; Harrison & Kwon, 2023).

2.3.1. Rethinking brand personification

Despite its intuitive appeal, recent scholarship has questioned the theoretical foundations of traditional brand personification measures. Current research shows that Brand Personification to some extent has loose theoretical justification and has been institutionalized without critically examining its legitimacy (Avis, 2012; Avis & Aitken, 2015; Roy & Banerjee, 2025).

Avis & Aitken (2015) note that once brand relationships became popular in marketing, personification was assumed and embedded in branding theory rather than rigorously justified. However, while brands are inherently social creations (Muñiz & O'Guinn, 2001), the fact that consumers can personify brands does not automatically imply that brands function as human-like actors (Avis & Aitken, 2015). Similarly, Roy and Banerjee (2025) observe that much research has clustered around validating and adapting Aaker's (1997) scale across cultures, but has not challenged its core assumptions, suggesting a theoretical stagnation.

Traditional Brand Personality models also tend to not sufficiently differentiate between brand traits and product-category traits, and there is little consensus on which traits truly belong to "personality" versus brand identity (Avis, 2012). More fundamentally, many studies treat a brand's personality as a static formulaic outcome, not as an organic exploratory process (Roy & Banerjee, 2025). Anthropomorphism is not a singular psychological process; it can result from multiple managerial tactics and consumer attributions (Sharma & Rahman, 2022). Cues that make a brand seem human can come from internal stakeholders, front-line employees, spokespeople, or even the brand's online interface, implying that personification rarely has a single source (Siano et al., 2022; Sharma & Rahman, 2022).

Empirical evidence also suggests that personification depends heavily on context. Aguirre-Rodriguez (2013) argues that one's interpretation of brand personification is heavily dependent on cultural background. Similarly, Fielden-Burns and Piquer-Píriz (2022) show that figurative personification arises from topic-specific metaphors rather than a general belief that brands literally are sentient people. According to Ashman and Winstanley (2007), this separation between metaphor and human is important, since personifying a company can blur responsibilities by downplaying the role of real decision-makers behind a figurative "corporate persona" curtain.

Oklevik et al. (2020) demonstrate this by using open-ended associations: when consumers freely describe brands, the human-like associations they report are highly contextual and tied to specific figures or situations. Based on this insight, Oklevik et al. (2020) propose a Human Brand Associations (HBA) framework to move beyond trait lists. Their HBA framework categorizes brand-related human associations into three types: Brand Representatives, Brand Characters, and Brand Users. This approach acknowledges that human associations with a brand can take various concrete forms, which is especially useful when we later analyze personification at different firm stages.

In summary, past research shows that personifying a brand, whether through characters, spokespersons, or tone-of-voice, can make the brand seem more human and relatable (Cohen, 2014; Fleck et al., 2014; Zeitoun et al., 2020; Harrison & Kwon, 2023). However, personification is not a unitary phenomenon, and its drivers and effects may accordingly change with context. Brand personification can therefore be understood as a strategic practice of connecting the brand with human-like attributes or symbols, so that consumers perceive the brand as having social, human-like characteristics. This includes using real people, created personas, and user imagery as carriers of brand meaning.

For conceptual clarity, this thesis distinguishes between brand meaning and brand personification. Brand meaning refers to the core idea, purpose, values, and interpretive principles through which a brand is understood by both the organisation and its stakeholders. It includes what the organisation believes the brand stands for, as well as the meanings that consumers, employees, communities, and other actors ascribe to it. Brand personification, by contrast, refers to the humanised enactment of that meaning. It occurs when specific people, figures, or user groups become visible carriers through which the brand is interpreted as human-like. The two concepts therefore overlap, since personification can carry brand meaning, but they remain analytically distinct. Brand meaning concerns the content being interpreted, while brand personification concerns the human or human-like mechanism through which that content becomes socially recognisable.

2.4. Organizational growth models

Stage models are commonly used to explain how organizations develop over time through a series of qualitatively different stages, each characterized by specific structures, challenges, and processes (McMahon, 1998). These models generally assume sequential and hierarchical development, where organizations move through stages as they adapt to increasing complexity (Solli-Sæther & Gottschalk, 2010). A central concept within stage theory is that of dominant problems, meaning that each stage is defined by the primary organizational challenges faced at that point in development (Kazanjian, 1988). As these challenges are resolved, new ones emerge, driving transition into the next stage.

McMahon (1998) argues that stage models of firm growth like that of Galbraith (1982) suggest that businesses evolve through phases in which their size, structure, and strategic priorities change systematically. One influential example is the enterprise life-cycle model developed by Hanks et al. (1994), which identifies stages such as start-up, expansion, maturity, and diversification, each associated with increasing organizational complexity and specialization. As firms move through these stages, managerial challenges shift accordingly.

However, stage models have also been criticized for being overly linear and lacking empirical validation, since organizational development in practice is often overlapping and context-dependent (Teo & King, 1997; Solli-Sæther & Gottschalk, 2010). To address this,

Solli-Sæther and Gottschalk (2010) propose an iterative model-building process that combines theoretical work and empirical work, thereby strengthening both the explanatory power and practical relevance of stage-based frameworks. Their proposed process consists of five sequential steps, as seen in the figure below and further explained in Appendix C.

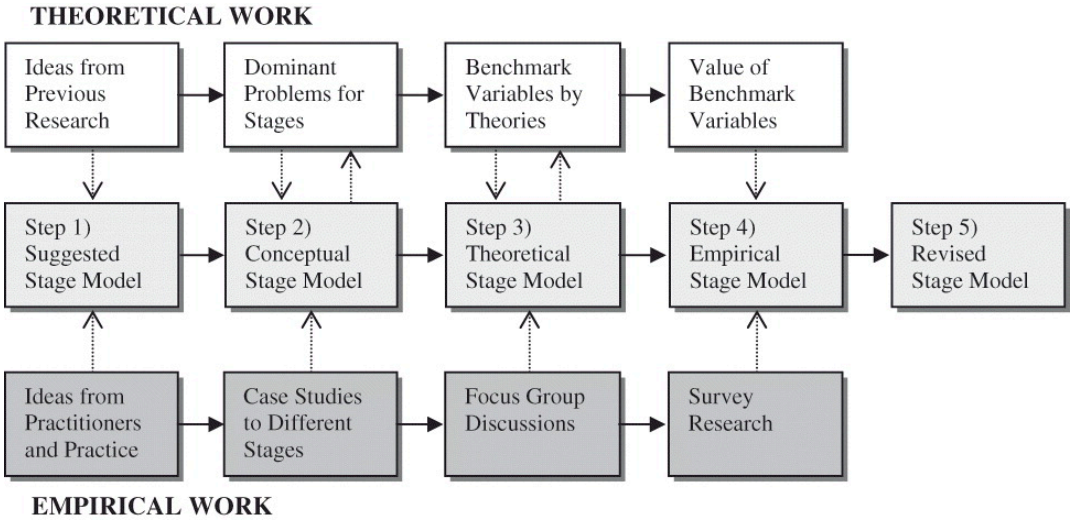


Figure 1: Suggested procedure for the stages of growth modeling process (Solli-Sæther & Gottschalk, 2010)

This framework conceptualizes stage modeling not as a one-time activity, but as a continuous iterative process of refinement. In this study, the role of the stage model is therefore to conceptualize organizational growth as a catalyst for transitional brand personification dynamics, and to provide a basis for examining how these dynamics appear in practice.

As firms develop from founder-led start-ups into more complex organizations, the ways brands are represented and personified are also likely to change. Inspired by organizational growth frameworks, particularly Hanks et al. (1994), the model identifies dominant characteristics that distinguish different stages, such as founder centrality, formalized brand guidelines, and how widely brand representation is distributed across organizational actors. However, since organizations may display traits from multiple stages simultaneously, the model should be treated as a heuristic tool rather than a rigid classification system.

Based on this logic, this study proposes a three-stage brand personification continuum, where the sources and mechanisms of brand personification evolve alongside organizational development and increasing complexity. Each stage represents a different balance of personification sources and strategies, which will be analysed in the following sections.

The stages from Hanks et al. (1994) are denominated with roman numerals (I to IV), following the formatting in their paper. Meanwhile the stages of our model will be referred to with Western Arabic numerals (1 to 3). This is done for clarity and to minimize confusion.

Below you can see the visual representation of the proposed Brand Personification Continuum. In the Concentration stage, BP is mostly tied with the founder of the business. In the Distribution stage, BP becomes less expressed through the founder and is distributed through the employees shaping or delivering the brand experience. In the Dispersion stage, BP becomes scattered and requires a re-discovery action, which can be understood through the Human Brand Associations (Oklevik et al., 2020).

Growth stages per Hanks et al. (1994)	**Our organizational branding stages**	**Our implications**
Start-up (I)	Stage 1: Concentration	Founder-personified brand
Expansion (II) / (early) Maturity (III)	Stage 2: Distribution	Internal brand alignment
Maturity (III) / Diversification (IV)	Stage 3: Dispersion	Scattered brand personification → understood through HBAs (Oklevik et al., 2020)

Table 1: Theoretical justification of the organizational stage model

2.5. Brand Personification Continuum

2.5.1. Stage 1: Concentration

The first stage consists of relatively newly created companies. This follows Hanks et al.'s (1994) description of Stage I companies as "relatively young, small, highly centralized and informal, focusing on the development and early commercialization of their [...] product(s)" (pp. 20-21). Among these are startups, which are fast-growing innovation-driven new ventures (European Commission, 2016). Additionally, "regular" younger companies and ventures that are not necessarily focused on innovation or growth are also included.

In the earliest stage of the continuum, brand personification is not usually the result of a formal branding strategy in the way branding literature may assume. Instead, it emerges through the founder's identity, behaviour, communication style, and everyday interactions (McCarthy et al., 2023; Shi, 2019). Because early-stage ventures are small and often lack established brand assets, stakeholders mainly interpret the brand through the founder, who becomes the primary carrier of brand meaning (Centeno et al., 2019). As the lines between owner and manager are blurred, this founder-centric visibility acts as a practical mental shortcut for consumers who lack

prior experience of the firm (Astner & Gaddefors, 2025). Thus, the brand's personality is effectively grounded in the founder's being, as the founder projects their own traits onto the brand, intrinsically personifying it (Spence & Essoussi, 2010).

This stage represents the most concentrated form of brand personification, dominated by the founder and a small group of early employees (Yönel et al., 2026). Research on new venture branding shows that founders often use personal narratives, values, and self-presentation to build legitimacy and differentiate the firm (Astner & Gaddefors, 2025). In practice, the founder and the brand therefore become closely intertwined, especially in environments where consumers have little prior knowledge of the company (Yönel et al., 2026).

Start-ups also face challenges such as limited resources, low awareness, and the “liability of newness,” making branding an important tool for gaining legitimacy and trust (Yönel et al., 2026). Since early-stage brands have limited market presence, founder-related cues can become proxies for credibility, helping consumers “fill in” the brand’s character before long-term customer experiences exist (Eggers et al., 2016; Huang & Mitchell, 2014). In this first stage, that “personality” is often less a stable list of traits and more a lived pattern of behaviour and narrative performance, where the founder’s identity and choices become the material that stakeholders interpret as brand meaning (Törmälä & Gyrd-Jones, 2017; Cohen, 2014).

Importantly, founder-driven branding is communicated, performed, and tested through repeated interactions, feedback, and recalibration rather than a fixed master plan (Chaudhri et al., 2022). This helps explain why early brand identity can appear coherent externally even when the organisation itself remains unfinished internally (Törmälä & Gyrd-Jones, 2017; Chaudhri et al., 2022). Furthermore, new ventures are not immune to subjectivity. Some brand attributes matter more than others depending on the type of consumer (Eggers et al., 2016). In Stage 1, personification thus reflects context-sensitive interpretations of founder and organizational cues as human-like identity signals (Cohen, 2014; Fielden-Burns & Piquer-Píriz, 2022).

This founder-centric form of personification aligns with Cohen’s (2014) “reality continuum” of brand personification. Rather than relying on fictional mascots or constructed characters, Stage 1 brands are personified through real people. The founder becomes the most visible and credible “face” of the brand, shaping how audiences interpret its values, intentions, and personality (Centeno et al., 2019; Spence & Essoussi, 2010). This differs from later stages, where personification becomes more distributed across employees, executives, influencers, or fictional brand assets.

Digital-first environments strengthen this effect. Founders frequently communicate directly with audiences through social media, becoming the brand’s public voice. Chen et al. (2015) show that conversational and human-like communication online increases engagement and facilitates consumers into treating brands as social actors. In Stage 1, this often happens without formal brand systems, as audiences respond directly to the founder’s communication style and interactions.

This stage also highlights the limitations of fixed trait-based personality models, as early-stage personification remains fluid and founder-dependent (Avis, 2012; Roy & Banerjee, 2025). A stage-sensitive perspective therefore suggests that early brand personification is better understood through founder cues, narrative consistency, and interaction style rather than predefined personality dimensions.

However, as brands develop, they often start to deviate from founders' identities due to stakeholder pressure, both internally and externally, indicating that early-stage personification can be both powerful and fragile (Astner & Gaddefors, 2025). As a consequence, changes in founder behaviour, visibility, or public perception can quickly alter how the brand is interpreted (McCarthy et al., 2023; Shi, 2019; Astner & Gaddefors, 2025). This means that branding at this stage is highly dynamic. Ventures continuously adjust their messaging and identity as they learn what resonates with stakeholders and what they can credibly claim (Chaudhri et al., 2022).

As ventures grow, founder-driven personification becomes harder to sustain due to expanding communication channels, employees, and stakeholder groups. This gradually shifts personification away from the founder alone and toward more distributed forms of brand representation (Braxton & Lau-Gesk, 2020).

The dominant characteristic of organizations in Stage 1 could therefore be understood as acting upon an "embodied" form of brand personification. Consequently, it is important here to strategically prioritize specific brand signals rather than trying to communicate everything at once. Coherent personification efforts may more or less automatically bear fruit when a small set of brand message cues are repeated consistently. In other words, the small scale of Stage 1 organizations often prompts the founder to become the primary human representation of the brand before more formalized branding systems emerge.

2.5.2. Stage 2: Distribution

Once the founder cannot embody the brand everywhere anymore, firms may need internal branding and identity management efforts to create coherence and alignment. This leads us to the second stage. The second stage is represented by growing small and medium-sized companies, often falling into the term SME, reflecting stage II and the start of stage III in Hanks et al. (1994).

In this stage, the core change is not only that the firm becomes "bigger", but that brand personification increasingly depends on organizational coordination. As companies grow, customer interactions and branding responsibilities become distributed across employees, teams, and departments (Juntunen, 2025), rather than remaining concentrated around the founder. Although founders may still influence branding decisions in growing SMEs (Centeno et al., 2019; Spence & Essoussi, 2010), there is a higher need for coherent internal branding within the firm (Saleem & Iglesias, 2016).

As opposed to employer branding, which communicates the company to potential employees, internal branding helps create organizational coherence (King & Grace, 2008; Scheffer & Crystal, 2008; Saleem & Iglesias, 2016). This coherence is crucial because, especially in service settings, frontline employees often become the most direct representation of the brand (Braxton & Lau-Gesk, 2020). By understanding and internalizing the brand, employees are able to personify it through their tone, behaviour, and service delivery (King & Grace, 2008). As a result, personification is no longer concentrated in the founder alone, but enacted collectively through multiple actors within the organization.

This perspective treats internal stakeholders as central carriers of brand meaning. King and Grace (2010) illustrate this through their Employee-Based Brand Equity (EBBE) model, which shows how internal brand management practices influence how employees deliver the brand. In practical terms, customers experience the brand's "personality" through employees' tone, competence, helpfulness, and consistency. Branding is therefore built not only through logos or advertising, but through everyday employee interactions (Sirianni et al., 2013). When consumers lack prior experience with the brand, they rely more heavily on interpersonal and behavioural cues to understand "who the brand is" (Eggers et al., 2016; Sirianni et al., 2013). Internal alignment therefore improves both organizational consistency and coherent brand interpretation.

At the same time, Stage 2 introduces new vulnerabilities. Since brand meaning is increasingly carried by employees, organizations become more dependent on tacit knowledge embedded in individuals and workplace culture (Andrews, 2017; Yıldız et al., 2025). Tacit knowledge refers to personal, experience-based knowledge that is not easily communicated or written down (Philipson & Kjellström, 2020). Employee turnover can therefore disrupt organizational identity and weaken consistency, especially when knowledge and behavioural norms are difficult to formalize (Andrews, 2017; Philipson & Kjellström, 2020). Maintaining coherent personification consequently requires ongoing training, communication, and internal coordination.

Digital communication further expands this challenge, as growing firms must maintain a consistent human tone across multiple employees, teams, and platforms. Research by Jeong et al. (2022) and Barcelos et al. (2018) shows that brands using conversational and human tones-of-voice online generate stronger perceptions of social presence, engagement, and purchase intentions among customers. In Stage 2, tone-of-voice guidelines and communication norms therefore become important tools for maintaining a consistent personified impression across digital channels.

However, Stage 2 also reveals the limits of internal control. As organizations expand and stakeholder interactions increase, brand meaning becomes increasingly co-created with external actors such as customers, influencers, and online communities (Juntunen, 2025). In other words, how a brand evolves in the market today is largely outside the company's immediate control (Siano et al., 2022; Juntunen, 2025). Brands can still emit a message, but they cannot fully regulate how it is perceived, interpreted, projected, or spread (Hautala et al., 2026), while potentially having to take accountability if it becomes harmful (Siano et al., 2022).

Firms at this stage should therefore strengthen internal alignment while learning to manage increasingly distributed forms of brand meaning (Juntunen, 2025; Siano et al., 2022; Braxton & Lau-Gesk, 2020). Internal branding and employee coordination remain necessary for maintaining consistency, but they are no longer sufficient on their own for coherent brand identity during organizational growth.

All taken together, the dominant characteristic of Stage 2 is its increasing organizational complexity. The central theme is its position as a transitional phase between concentrated founder-driven personification in Stage 1 and more decentralized forms of personification in Stage 3. Firms must stabilize the brand internally while learning to manage external stakeholder influence and co-creation dynamics. Here, even “perfectly” coordinated internal enactment cannot fully control how the brand’s meaning is interpreted and negotiated across its stakeholder networks.

2.5.3. Stage 3: Dispersion

The third stage in our continuum concerns larger corporations and multinational enterprises (MNEs), corresponding to stage III and IV in Hanks et al.’s (1994) model. Here, brand personification can no longer be explained through a single “carrier” such as a founder (cf. Stage 1) or even an internally aligned employee base or a brand personification framework (cf. Stage 2). The changes at this stage stem not only from organisational size, but also from increasingly dispersed brand meaning across wider stakeholder ecosystems, channels, and intermediaries. Thus, the image of a company is constructed from the associations and descriptions influenced by external perceptions (Gorbaniuk et al., 2017; Fetscherin & Usunier, 2012). In hyperconnected markets, branding boundaries broaden and blur because the brand is interacted with, talked about, and evaluated through a growing set of stakeholder relationships that extend beyond the firm’s direct control (Swaminathan et al., 2020). As a result, the individual company’s brand personification approach may differ, to get their brand meaning message across as effectively as possible.

This distinction becomes especially important in Stage 3. Dispersed brand meaning does not automatically mean that every stakeholder is personifying the brand. A stakeholder may interpret the brand’s purpose, values, market position, or social role without becoming a personification source. Personification occurs when a human actor, recognisable figure, or user image becomes a visible point through which the brand is understood. In corporate contexts, this may happen through leadership, service staff, retail encounters, endorsers, influencers, or user communities. These actors do not replace brand meaning. They embody, translate, amplify, or contest it in specific encounters. Consequently, Stage 3 should be understood as the point where brand meaning is increasingly carried through many humanised touchpoints, making the perceived brand character harder to govern through a single internal voice.

This scaling dynamic is consistent with the broader shift in branding research from a control paradigm, where firms are treated as primary “owners” of brand meaning, toward a co-creation paradigm where brand meaning is increasingly negotiated with multiple stakeholders. Siano et al. (2022) frame this as a transition in which managers are encouraged to replace unilateral control with participatory approaches because digital environments and stakeholder empowerment make single-author branding less realistic.

In Stage 3, this implies a practical and methodological consequence for studying personification. As the number of brand touchpoints expands, personification is more likely to be produced through recurring human associations distributed across the organisation and its wider networks (Oklevik et al., 2020; Sharma & Rahman, 2022). Brand managers cannot therefore assume that a brand’s “human character” is fully captured by a pre-defined trait inventory or a single communication voice. Instead, corporate-scale personification requires mapping the brand’s human associations across stakeholder interactions, treating brand personification as something that organically unfolds across touchpoints rather than through predetermined labels (Avis & Aitken, 2015; Oklevik et al., 2020; Sharma & Rahman, 2022; Roy & Banerjee, 2025).

2.5.4. Human Brand Associations as the corporation-stage lens

Oklevik et al. (2020) provide the most concrete stepping stone for our Stage 3 logic, as their critique targets the same structural issue that becomes acute at corporate scale. More touchpoints and stakeholders at play does not simplify the process of defining personification (cf. Sharma & Rahman, 2022). Oklevik et al. (2020) found that factor-based brand personality measures often rely on predetermined labels and projective instructions that may not reflect how people naturally store and retrieve brand meaning. In their qualitative study based on free associations across multiple brands, categories, and cultural contexts, they argue that brand personality traits are “practically non-existent” in real associative networks and propose a shift toward their Human Brand Associations (HBA) framework.

The core contribution of the HBA framework is that it redirects personification research away from abstract trait inventories and toward concrete “figures” that become linked to the brand in people’s memory. Oklevik et al. (2020) propose three particularly relevant categories of HBAs: Brand representatives, Brand characters, and Brand users. Brand representatives concern people associated with the management or production of the branded offering, including employees and leadership (Zeitoun et al., 2020; Fleck et al., 2014). Brand characters concern real people or fictional figures strategically linked to the brand through communication (Reddy & Satish, 2023). Brand users concern typical user profiles and stereotypes tied to the brand (Xie et al., 2020; cf. Aaker, 2010).

This framework is especially useful for Stage 3 as it is inherently scale-sensitive. When brands become large enough that stakeholders’ brand experiences are mediated through multiple

human and symbolic “carriers”, HBAs offer a way to operationalise that dispersion without collapsing it back into a single trait profile. Our Stage 3 development therefore treats Oklevik et al.’s (2020) HBAs as the organising backbone for corporate-scale personification, while extending the framework in a stage-specific way by differentiating internal and external HBAs within each category.

2.5.4.1. (HBA1) Brand Representatives - internal and external carriers at corporate scale

Within Oklevik et al.'s HBA structure, brand representatives include both leadership and employees who become linked to the brand through repeated exposure, interaction, and communication. In Stage 3, we refine this by distinguishing between internal representatives and external representatives. Internal representatives include corporate leadership and employees who shape the brand from inside the organisation but are not consistently encountered by consumers in everyday service contact. External representatives include roles that regularly enact the brand in public-facing interaction, including front-line employees and other recurring “voices” that customers experience directly, both offline and online.

This split matters as empirical research suggests that external representatives are not merely operational executors of a pre-defined brand promise, but active producers of the brand’s personified impression through lived encounters. Research on branded service encounters demonstrates that aligning front-line employee behaviour with brand positioning improves overall brand evaluations and customer-based brand equity, especially where customers have fewer prior cues to rely on (Sirianni et al., 2013; Eggers et al., 2016). At corporate scale, this becomes a recurrent issue as brands enter new markets, formats, and digital contexts.

The importance of external representatives also becomes clearer when personification is conceptualised as collective rather than individual. Braxton and Lau-Gesk (2020) show that customer happiness and brand loyalty can be strengthened when front-line service providers align with the brand persona and store environment. In Stage 3 terms, corporations increasingly depend on this kind of collective personification because many customers’ experiences are built through repeated interactions with rotating employees, physical environments, and standardised service scripts.

At the same time, corporate-scale personification cannot assume that front-line groups respond uniformly to branding initiatives. Boukis et al. (2021) challenge the idea that front-line employees are a homogeneous group, identifying distinct types of corporate brand construal and showing why variations in how employees interpret the corporate brand help explain differences in brand promise delivery. In other words, in service contexts, front-line employees become crucial carriers of brand meaning, as they often are the most easily accessible brand touchpoint (Sirianni et al, 2013; King & Grace, 2010). This reinforces the point that Stage 3 personification is not only dispersed, but also internally heterogeneous.

Internal representatives remain important in Stage 3, but their role shifts. Rather than functioning as the primary personification source, internal leadership becomes one influential node within a wider network of personifiers. Internal endorsement research supports this logic by showing that CEOs and employees featured as spokespersons can shape corporate brand meaning through credibility, congruity, and storytelling mechanisms (Zeitoun et al., 2020; Fleck et al., 2014). While external employees shape the day-to-day perception of brand personification, leadership and internal employees become personification anchors that signal what the corporation “stands for.”

2.5.4.2. (HBA2) Brand Characters - internal assets and external endorsers

Oklevik et al. (2020) define brand characters as real people or fictitious personal figures strategically associated with the brand through communication. These exist as a visual prompt to reflect the brand through some kind of embodiment of its image, values and personality, helping consumers recognize, recall, and understand the brand (Reddy & Satish, 2023; Oklevik et al., 2020). This category becomes especially important in Stage 3, since corporations often rely on characters to re-stabilise personification across markets where organisational representatives cannot be consistently visible.

Within our Stage 3 structuring, we differentiate between internal characters and external characters. Internal characters are owned and authored by the corporation, such as brand-created mascots or recurring fictional figures. Because they are internally governed, they can be designed to express a stable personality script and can be updated without relying on independent reputation dynamics. Anthropomorphic brand mascots have shown to have a positive effect on brand attractiveness and consumer purchase intentions by fostering emotional connections and brand awareness (Reddy & Satish, 2023; Cayla, 2013).

External characters, by contrast, include endorsers and influencers who bring their own independent “human brand” meanings and therefore introduce both amplification potential and alignment risk. Fleck et al. (2014) describe brand personification through advertising spokespeople across celebrities, ordinary people, and founders or CEOs, and emphasise that effectiveness depends in part on perceived congruence and how audiences interpret the spokesperson’s role in humanising the brand. This is coherent with our Stage 3 view because corporations often deploy people-based character strategies as scalable shortcuts for humanising brands across mass communication.

Influencer marketing further amplifies the Stage 3 relevance of external characters since influencers can operate as human brands in their own right. Ki et al. (2020) show that followers’ emotional attachment to social media influencers is a key antecedent to endorsement effectiveness. However, attention should be put on the alignment between the brand and the influencer, as notions of inauthentic endorsement may erode consumer confidence in the brand in question (Kim & Kim, 2021). Thus, the influencer needs to be sufficiently compatible with the company’s brand meaning for it to work successfully.

For Stage 3, this means a corporation does not simply “borrow attention” when partnering with an influencer. It also links its brand personification to the influencer’s existing human brand association network.

2.5.4.3. (HBA3) Brand Users - internal communities and external publics

Oklevik et al. (2020) position brand users as typical user profiles and stereotypes associated with a brand. This category is particularly valuable for Stage 3 because, at corporate scale, user-related personification does not remain a peripheral association. Instead, user meanings become a major route through which consumers infer what the brand “is”, who it is “for”, and what kind of social identity it signals.

In our Stage 3 structuring, the internal-external split within HBA users distinguishes between existing users who have direct experience and community participation surrounding the brand, and external users who include non-users, potential users, and publics whose impressions are shaped largely through indirect information, stereotypes, and market narratives.

Internal users are people who currently choose or prefer the brand in question. This includes committed users and brand communities, illustrating the parasocial aspect of brand relationships (Huang & Mitchell, 2014). Brand communities are defined by Muñiz and O’Guinn (2001) as specialised, non-geographically bound communities structured around social relations among admirers of a brand, with hyperconnectivity further strengthening these community dynamics (Swaminathan et al., 2020; Marchowska-Raza & Rowley, 2024).

The internal side of (HBA3) users therefore includes not only “who currently buys”, but also the structured narratives users collectively maintain about what the brand represents. In Stage 3 terms, this can strengthen brand meaning coherence because users reproduce a consistent persona story. It can also create governance pressure because highly involved users may claim interpretive ownership, criticise corporate decisions, or resist identity shifts, reinforcing the idea that brand meaning becomes co-authored at scale (Muniz & O’Guinn, 2001; Swaminathan et al., 2020).

The external side of (HBA3) users is equally important because non-users and loosely connected publics often rely on imagined user profiles when forming attitudes, called typical user imagery. This illustrates the stereotyped perception of a general user of a particular brand (Parker, 2009). Xie et al. (2020) argue that brand user imagery is a central aspect of brand associations and develop the construct of brand user imagery clarity (BUIC), emphasising how brand user imagery is organised in memory. In the logic of our continuum, BUIC becomes especially relevant for Stage 3 because corporations are often present across multiple segments and cultural contexts, which can lead to blurred or contradictory “typical user” imagery.

Similarly, brand users shape a brand's image by acting as social reference groups (Yang et al., 2023). The characteristics and group identity of users can become directly representative of how others perceive and assess the brand. If new users have a perceived positive social status, the brand's reputation may improve. If new users are from undesired or stigmatized social groups, the brand image may suffer, and original users may reduce their repurchase intentions or abandon the brand completely (Ward & Dahl, 2014; Weitzl & Hutzinger, 2025; Yang et al., 2023). In other words, the brand meaning is affected by those you associate it with.

User-based personification also has a negative and conflictual side that becomes highly visible in Stage 3. Hyperconnectivity enables publics to form counter-communities and anti-brand meaning systems that personify the brand in hostile ways. Swaminathan et al. (2020) describe how anti-brand activists and cultural intermediaries can introduce competing brand meanings, including doppelgänger brand images that influence consumer behaviour. Puzakova et al. (2013) found that consumers tend to react more negatively when an anthropomorphised brand does wrong. Brandão and Popoli (2023) add that anthropomorphism can expedite blame mechanisms when it is used to express negative feelings and attributions of responsibility.

This supports a Stage 3 claim that is structurally different from Stage 1 and Stage 2: at corporate scale, the brand's personified impression is shaped not only by what the firm and its aligned employees enact, but also by external user-based reinterpretations and oppositional identity work. Here, thinking about the brand in human terms becomes very tangible, as the mental image is sculpted by an intertwined perspective of those who choose to represent it, along with those who may resent it. However, the measures taken with this image in mind is what ultimately shapes the brand.

2.5.4.4. Governance and risk in hyperconnected co-creation

Stage 3 requires explicitly linking personification to governance because corporate-scale personification happens in a context where brand meaning is both widely distributed and increasingly vulnerable to disruption. Swaminathan et al. (2020) describe how porous brand ownership increases the risk of crises arising from the actions of partners, employees, and other stakeholders, and argue that hyperconnectivity changes how brands should be managed.

This governance need is mirrored in the co-creation paradigm literature, which stresses that co-creation is not always collaborative. Siano et al. (2022) differentiate constructive co-creation from non-collaborative and potentially destructive processes such as brand hijacking, while Juntunen (2025) notes that co-creation can involve protective, playful, or hijacking stakeholder influence that makes communication unpredictable for the company. Multi-stakeholder brand meaning is therefore not automatically aligned with managerial intent.

From a personification-specific angle, Sharma and Rahman (2022) help clarify why Stage 3 governance is not only about communication management but also about the sources and mechanisms of anthropomorphism itself. By distinguishing constructed brand

anthropomorphism and perceived brand anthropomorphism, they underline that (anthropomorphic) brand meaning can be both marketer-generated and consumer-generated. This duality aligns with our Stage 3 internal-external HBA split: internal approaches can design personification cues through representatives and characters, while external processes can reinterpret and sometimes contest personification through user discourse and platform dynamics.

The risk dimension becomes especially important when brands face wrongdoing narratives, because personification can increase moralised evaluation. Puzakova et al. (2013) show that anthropomorphising a brand can worsen consumer evaluations when the brand faces negative publicity caused by product wrongdoings. Similar patterns can be observed when combined with evidence that online anti-brand communities sometimes use anthropomorphism to attribute responsibility and intensify hate toward a brand (Brandão & Popoli, 2023). The implication for Stage 3 is that corporate-scale brands must manage both how they humanise their own persona and how personification dynamics shape blame, moral judgement, and hostile relationship formation in networked publics (Siano et al., 2022).

The dominant characteristic of organizations in Stage 3 is therefore dispersion. These literatures together justify the central Stage 3 claim in the proposed diagnostic continuum: brand personification at corporate scale must be approached as an inductive mapping problem rather than a static identity proclamation. Since the brand's perceived "human character" is distributed across its internal and external representatives, characters, and users, corporations can benefit from continuously re-examining what human associations are actually active in stakeholder memory, and where misalignments emerge across the brand's different touchpoints. Oklevik et al.'s (2020) HBA logic is therefore particularly useful here, since it lets researchers investigate which human figures, characters, and user profiles are spontaneously linked to the brand in associative networks.

All taken together, the authors therefore propose the Brand Personification Continuum Model as seen in the figure below.

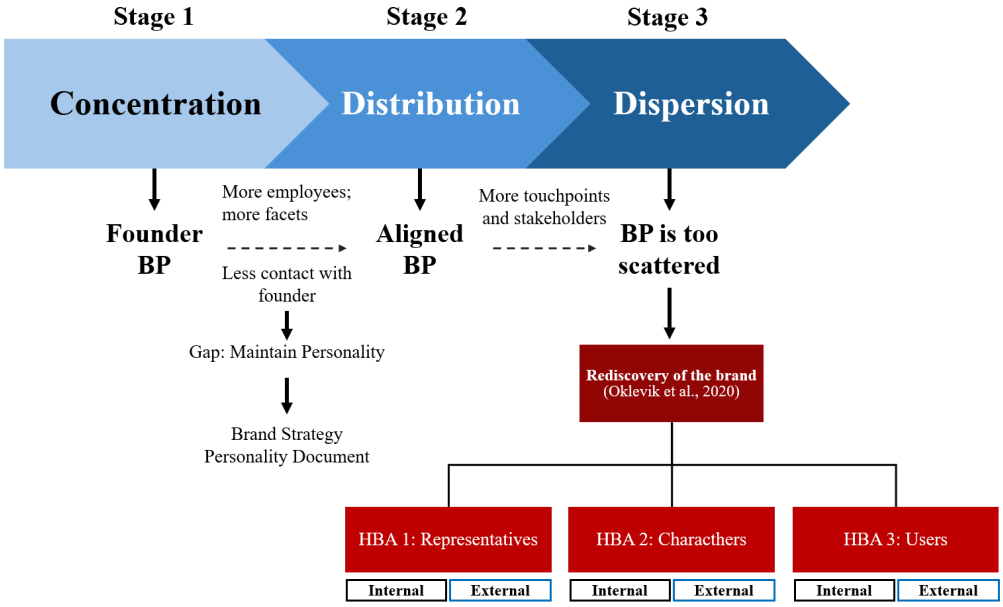


Figure 2: Proposed Brand Personification Continuum model

Further limitations of the continuum can be found in Appendix D.

3. Methodology

This chapter outlines the methodological approach used in the study. It explains the research design, interview procedure, sampling strategy, data analysis process, quality criteria, and ethical considerations. The chapter also clarifies how the empirical material was collected, transcribed, coded, and analysed in relation to the study's theoretical framework.

Since this chapter draws on methodology textbooks, page numbers are included where relevant to improve source transparency.

3.1. Choice of Methodological approach

The methodological approach adopted in this study can be described as deductive. This course of action is based on the fact that the research is initially guided by existing theory. (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 24-25). Thus, rather than developing theory inductively from the data, the qualitative interviews serve to explore and apply these theoretical concepts within different organisational contexts. The empirical material is therefore analysed through an established theoretical lens, allowing the study to examine how existing perspectives of brand personification manifest across varying stages of organisational growth. While the findings contribute to a deeper understanding and contextualisation of the framework, the primary direction of reasoning remains from theory to empirical observation (Nunan et al., 2020, pp. 155-156). As a result, deduction becomes the most appropriate characterization of the study's methodological approach.

3.1.1. Research philosophy

From a philosophical perspective, the study takes on a social constructivist ontological position. This means that social phenomena and entities are understood as shaped and constructed by social actors (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 28-30). Adopting a constructivist standpoint is appropriate for this study, as it allows the study to explore how different (social) actors interpret and enact brand personification in practice, and how these interpretations may vary across organizational contexts and stages of development.

Following this ontological position, the study adopts an interpretivist epistemological stance. Interpretivism assumes that knowledge about social phenomena cannot be understood purely through *objective measurement*, but instead requires interpreting the *subjective meanings* that individuals attach to their actions and experiences (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 31-36). This approach allows the study to examine how brand personification is understood, expressed, and managed across different organizational contexts.

3.1.2. Qualitative Research Method

This study is based on a combination of secondary data from the literature review and primary data collected through in-depth interviews. The reviewed literature provided the theoretical foundation of the study, while the interviews provided real-world managerial input into how brand personification is understood, expressed, and managed in practice.

Based on the identified gaps in this field of research, a qualitative research approach was considered most appropriate for this study. In particular, the study draws upon approaches by Chaudhri et al. (2022), Fleck et al. (2014) and, partially, Zeitoun et al. (2020). While a quantitative approach could have generated findings with stronger statistical generalizability (Antwi & Hamza, 2015; Bell et al., 2022, pp. 518-533), such an approach was not considered suitable for the present study.

Since the phenomenon is complex, context-dependent, and underdeveloped in the literature, qualitative methods allow for a more flexible and in-depth examination of how company representatives interpret and enact brand personification in practice. This enables richer insights into how participants interpret brand personification in a way that would not be possible through quantitative means.

3.2. Research strategy

3.2.1. Creation of constructs

Apart from giving a comprehensive view of the field of research, the literature review constituted the first step in a process of content validation, which is used to identify existing dimensions and definitions (Churchill, 1979). Based on the literature review, a set of constructs was developed. However, literature alone is not sufficient for ensuring high content validity. Qualitative methods, such as interviews, should therefore be used to refine, adapt, and expand constructs based on empirical input from the target population, ensuring their relevance for the specific context (Churchill, 1979).

The constructs used in this study were developed through a structured process grounded in the literature review. They were based on themes, patterns, tensions, and theoretical gaps found within the accumulated literature. To make these themes analytically workable, they were translated into operational categories with support from an AI-assisted sorting tool, which helped cluster related ideas and identify potential overlaps or redundancies.

The preliminary themes were then critically evaluated to determine which should remain independent constructs, be merged, refined, or removed. They were also structured to reflect the conceptual progression identified in the literature. Through this iterative refinement process, a final set of theoretically grounded and practically useful constructs was developed, anchoring

the qualitative approach in existing research while allowing empirical findings to refine and expand the emerging diagnostic model.

Name of Construct	Abbreviation	Meaning	Stages covered
Organizational Scale and Representational Complexity	OSRC	Size of company → complexity of Brand Personification	Comparison among stages 1 through 3
Personification Source Configuration	PSC	Personality of brand usually mirrors personality of founder	Mainly stage 1
Personification Governance and Internal Alignment	PGIA	Personification becomes more complex as the company grows → internal alignment may be required	Stage 2
Bridge from Distribution to Dispersion	BDD	More touchpoints emerge → uncontrollable co-creation → maintaining internal alignment difficult	Stage 2 → Stage 3
HBA Configuration and Alignment	HBACA	Brand Personification becomes too dispersed; requires rediscovery and diagnosis	Stage 3

Table 2: Construct Codebook for the Brand Personification Continuum

This structure later formed the foundation of the interview guide and ensured a logical flow of questions: from organizational scale, to personification sources, governance, dispersion, and stakeholder-specific human brand associations. The same constructs were later used to guide the coding and analysis process, creating a consistent analytical framework throughout the study.

3.3. Data collection instrument

3.3.1. Semi-structured interviews as data collection instrument

Semi-structured in-depth interviews were used as the study's primary data collection method. This format offered enough structure to ensure that all core constructs were addressed, while still allowing participants to elaborate on their experiences in their own words (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 427-429, 439; Kallio et al., 2016). This flexible format also made it possible to probe unclear

answers and explore issues that became analytically relevant during the interviews (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006).

All interviews were conducted online via video call to accommodate geographically dispersed participants and simplify scheduling (Archibald et al., 2019; Deakin & Wakefield, 2014). With participants' consent, the interviews were recorded and transcribed verbatim, which improved the transparency and traceability of the analysis by allowing repeated review of the material during coding and theme development (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 436-444; Poland, 1995).

3.3.2. Interview guideline

The interview guide ensured that the collected data addressed the specific aspects of brand personification and organizational development examined in the literature review. It was organised around the study's central constructs and was designed to move from contextual questions toward more reflective and interpretive ones (Kallio et al., 2016; Blumberg et al., 2025, pp. 268-269). In practice, the guide was not used as a rigid script, in line with semi-structured interviewing (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 430-436; Kallio et al., 2016). The full process of creating the interview guideline is found in Appendix H.

3.3.3. Final interview questions

The final interview questions were developed through a structured process that followed the conceptual framework of the study. Each question was designed to operationalize a specific construct (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 82-87, 430-431), allowing the study to examine how these constructs manifest in practice across different organizational contexts. The full list of interview questions and their corresponding constructs is presented in Appendices E, F and G.

3.3.4. Sampling approach

The study's unit of analysis consists of branding and marketing professionals representing their companies or reflecting on previous clients (Blumberg et al., 2025, p. 133). Since the study required participants with specific professional expertise, a non-probabilistic sampling approach was used, as this would be difficult to achieve through randomized means (Nunan et al., 2020, p. 412). In particular, this called for purposive and judgement sampling techniques (Daymon & Holloway, 2011, p. 212; Nunan et al., 2020, pp. 415-416).

The central selection criterion was that participants should hold, or have held, roles involving direct responsibility for shaping, managing, or communicating a brand. Following this logic, the sample consisted of professionals such as brand managers, brand strategists, marketing managers, branding consultants, founders, and CEOs. Regardless of professional title, the

central aspect taken into consideration was whether the person worked closely with brand development and representation (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 390-392; Palinkas et al., 2015; Patton, 2015).

The inclusion criteria were therefore that participants should either currently represent organisations within marketing, branding or communications, and that these organisations fall within the three stages of the proposed continuum, or that they had experienced and assisted the shift between stages from an outside perspective.

3.3.5. Recruitment of interviewees

In order to obtain a sufficiently satisfactory empirical basis, twelve respondents were recruited for interviews. These respondents were industry professionals representing companies that fall into one of the three stages respectively. To ensure a more balanced comparison, each stage was represented by four interviewees.

Stage	**Number of participants**
Concentration (1)	4
Distribution (2)	4
Dispersion (3)	4
Total	***12***

Table 3: Distribution of participants among stages

Most respondents were recruited through the researchers' professional networks, either as personal professional contacts or acquaintances of the researchers. This approach was used because the study required access to participants with relevant professional experience and insight into brand management processes. The interviewees were contacted individually and informed about the purpose of the study, the general topic of the interview, and how their responses would be used.

Name*	Country	Industry	BPC stage	Duration
AC	Georgia	Online casino	Dispersion (3)	39 minutes
MG	Canada	Woodworking	Distribution (2)	30 minutes
MK	Georgia	Tech	Concentration (1)	35 minutes
TB	Georgia	Construction	Distribution (2)	31 minutes
GK	Georgia	Winery	Concentration (1)	36 minutes
LA	US	Tech	Concentration (1)	26 minutes
GI	Georgia	Luxury Markets	Dispersion (3)	26 minutes
VV	Georgia	Tech	Dispersion (3)	46 minutes
AA	Georgia	Digital Media	Distribution (2)	48 minutes
AN	Georgia	Tech	Distribution (2)	35 minutes
SK	Georgia	Tech	Concentration (1)	34 minutes
LS	Georgia	Insurance	Dispersion (3)	47 minutes

Table 4: Overview of selected interviewees

This respondent table documents the composition of the sample and increases methodological transparency by showing how each participant fits into the study (O'Brien et al., 2014; Tong et al., 2007).

3.4. Data analysis approach

The data analysis followed the deductive logic of the study by interpreting the empirical material through the theoretical framework and analytical constructs developed from the literature review. Rather than merely describing the respondents' answers, the analysis examined how the empirical findings aligned with and illustrated the proposed Brand Personification Continuum across different organisational contexts. This approach enabled systematic comparisons between cases while grounding the interpretation in the study's predefined conceptual framework.

Since the study aims to understand how brand personification changes across organisational growth stages, the analysis focused on identifying patterns, differences, and tensions across the three proposed stages: Concentration, Distribution, and Dispersion. The analysis was organised around the five constructs developed earlier in the methodology: Organisational Scale and Representational Complexity, Personification Source Configuration, Personification Governance and Internal Alignment, Bridge from Distribution to Dispersion, and HBA Configuration and Alignment.

3.4.1. Qualitative data analysis

Qualitative data analysis is suitable when the aim is to interpret meaning, identify patterns, and understand how participants make sense of a phenomenon in context (Bell et al., 2022). In this study, this was relevant because brand personification was often described indirectly through founders, employees, customers, ambassadors, brand guidelines, organisational culture, community behaviour, and external interpretation.

The analysis therefore focused on connecting empirical statements to the study's conceptual framework, while allowing sufficient flexibility to capture context-specific nuances in the data. Responses were coded and interpreted in relation to the predefined analytical constructs derived from the literature review, enabling systematic comparisons across organisational stages. Although the researchers remained attentive to unexpected observations, these were interpreted within the existing theoretical framework rather than used to develop new theory (Nunan et al., 2020, pp. 228-229, 249). The qualitative data analysis thus followed a deductive logic and provided the foundation for the thematic analysis and coding process described below.

3.4.1.1. Thematic Analysis

In this study, thematic analysis was used to identify, organise, and interpret recurring patterns of meaning across the interview material (Clarke & Braun, 2017). This approach was suitable as the interview questions were developed from the study's core concepts and therefore produced data that could be analysed in relation to the constructs developed in the theoretical framework (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006; Kallio et al., 2016).

The analysis was also guided by Naeem et al.'s (2023) step-by-step process for thematic analysis, which is particularly relevant for qualitative studies that aim to move from empirical material toward conceptual model development. Their process outlines six steps: transcription and familiarisation with the data, selection of keywords, coding, theme development, conceptualisation through interpretation of keywords, codes and themes, and development of a conceptual model (Naeem et al., 2023). This was useful for the present study because the aim was to refine and assess the proposed Brand Personification Continuum through empirical interpretation.

Themes were selected on the basis of their relevance to the research question and analytical contribution regarding how brand personification changes across organisational growth stages (Clarke & Braun, 2017). In practice, the thematic analysis involved repeated reading of the transcripts, coding of relevant extracts, grouping related codes into sub-themes and broader themes, and comparing these themes across the three stages (Nowell et al., 2017).

The final themes emerged at two levels of abstraction. At the first level, themes captured stage-specific patterns, such as founder concentration at Stage 1, codified internal governance at Stage 2, and externally co-created brand meaning at Stage 3. At the second level, themes captured cross-stage dynamics, such as the internal-to-external split in human brand associations, founding narratives as governance mechanisms, and the tension between consistency and coherence in brand personification management.

Figure X: Systematic thematic analysis process (Naeem et al., 2023)

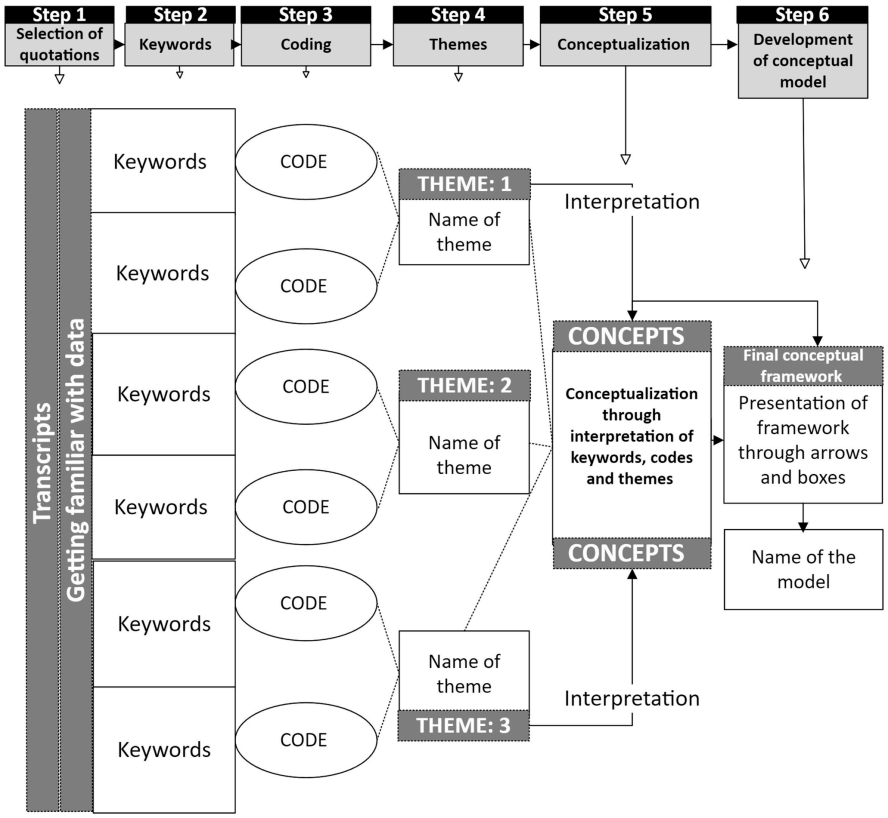


Figure 3: Systematic thematic analysis process (Naeem et al., 2023)

3.4.2. Coding of the data

The coding process began once the recorded interviews had been transcribed verbatim. Each transcript was read several times before detailed coding began (Miles et al., 2014; Saldaña, 2016). A shared codebook, derived from the literature review and construct development, was used as the basis for coding (Hruschka et al., 2004). In practice, this meant that the researchers

assigned labels to segments of text that reflected recurring ideas, mechanisms, tensions, or experiences related to the study's conceptual framework (Miles et al., 2014; Saldaña, 2016).

Although the codebook was theory-informed from the outset, the coding process was not treated as mechanically fixed. When empirical statements did not fit the initial categories well, the researchers revisited code definitions and refined them in light of the material. This reduced the risk of forcing the data into overly narrow preconceived categories and helped preserve the interpretive depth of the interviews (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006; Miles et al., 2014).

The coded material formed the basis for comparing similarities and differences across interviews and stages. Particular attention was paid to how participants described founder visibility, employee alignment, stakeholder co-creation, and external brand interpretation across Concentration, Distribution, and Dispersion.

The final coding structure was organised around the five constructs developed in the methodology: Organisational Scale and Representational Complexity, Personification Source Configuration, Personification Governance and Internal Alignment, Bridge from Distribution to Dispersion, and HBA Configuration and Alignment. These constructs provided the analytical structure for the findings chapter while still allowing inductive refinement where the empirical material introduced additional tensions or mechanisms. This follows the logic of Naeem et al. (2023), who argue that thematic analysis can combine deductive and inductive elements when moving from raw qualitative data toward a conceptual model.

3.5. Assessing quality of research

As qualitative research largely centres around in-depth subjective interpretations and logical inferences about specific contexts and situations, assessing quality through traditionally quantitative means might not be applicable. Reliability may not analogously fit in a qualitative study, as it can be difficult to replicate with identical results (Daymon & Holloway, 2011, pp. 78-79). Likewise, traditional notions of validity do not always work in the same way when conducting qualitative research (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 368-369; Stahl & King, 2020). Instead, the criteria for trustworthiness serve as the qualitative equivalent, covering aspects like coherence, applicability, and transparency.

3.5.1. Trustworthiness

While the study contributes to the broader discussion surrounding brand personification, its applicability must be interpreted with consideration for its specific context. Because of that, it is relevant to evaluate the quality of the study through criteria created for qualitative research (Bell et al., 2022, pp. 369-371). Trustworthiness provides a more context-sensitive judgment of

academic quality, recognizing the constructed and subjective nature of qualitative research (Stahl & King, 2020). It encompasses four main criteria: credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability, each addressing a different aspect of quality and rigor in the research process (Stahl & King, 2020).

3.5.1.1. Credibility

Credibility refers to how well the findings of a qualitative study reflect participants' experiences (Stahl & King, 2020). In this study, credibility was supported through the use of semi-structured interviews, verbatim transcription, systematic coding, and the use of respondent extracts in the findings chapter. However, due to the study's timeframe, credibility could not be strengthened through more extensive procedures such as triangulation or member checking (Daymon & Holloway, 2011, pp. 89-90). This means that credibility is supported by transparency in the research process, but remains limited by the absence of follow-up validation with participants.

3.5.1.2. Transferability

Transferability refers to the extent to which findings from one context can be applied to other settings or groups (Stahl & King, 2020). The sample of this study mainly reflects the perspectives of professionals reachable through the researchers' networks, and will most likely reflect a Western and/or European perspective. Given the qualitative nature of the study, the findings are not intended to be statistically generalisable. Instead, transferability depends on whether future researchers and readers find the contextual description sufficiently relevant for comparison with other organisational or geographical settings.

3.5.1.3. Dependability

Dependability concerns the consistency and traceability of the research process over time (Stahl & King, 2020). In this study, dependability was supported by documenting the methodological choices, explaining the sampling logic, presenting the interview process, and using a construct-based coding structure. By transparently justifying why certain participants were chosen and how the sample fits the aim of the study, the logic of the research process becomes possible to follow, even if the exact results are not directly replicable.

3.5.1.4. Confirmability

Confirmability concerns the degree to which findings are shaped by the participants and not only by researcher bias (Stahl & King, 2020). In this study, confirmability was supported by grounding the analysis in interview transcripts, using coded extracts, and linking findings back to the constructs developed from the literature. The analytical process was made explicit so that readers can see how the empirical material informed the interpretation and refinement of the Brand Personification Continuum.

3.6. Ethical considerations

Ethical considerations were taken into account throughout the research process, from the recruitment of participants to the handling and presentation of the empirical material. Since the study relied on interviews with professionals discussing branding practices, organisational processes, and internal decision-making, it was important to ensure informed consent, voluntary participation, confidentiality, and responsible data handling (Bell et al., 2019, pp. 112-130; Swedish Research Council, 2025).

3.6.1. Research ethics regulations

The study followed the general principles of research ethics outlined by the Swedish Research Council, including reliability, honesty, respect, and accountability. These principles were relevant in ensuring that the participants understood the purpose of the study, how their responses would be used, and what rights they had before, during, and after participation (Swedish Research Council, 2023; Swedish Research Council, 2025). By following ethical guidelines and principles, it is possible to ensure that the study has been conducted in a responsible and respectful manner, representing the participants fairly (Bell et al., 2019, pp. 112-130; Swedish Research Council, 2025).

3.6.2. Ethical treatment of participants

As qualitative data collection relies on gaining participants' trust, it is important to avoid exploiting this trust and to comply with applicable laws and regulations (Daymon & Holloway, 2011, p. 55; Bell et al., 2019, pp. 112-130; British Sociological Association, 2017). Before taking part in the interviews, all participants were informed about the purpose of the study, their rights and protection, and how the collected material would be used. Consent was obtained before the interviews were conducted (Blumberg et al., 2025, pp. 97-100; Swedish Research Council, 2025).

Care was also taken to avoid unnecessary intrusion into sensitive company matters. Since the interviews concerned branding, communication, internal alignment, and organisational processes, some answers could involve strategic or commercially sensitive information. For this reason, participants were not pressured to disclose information they were uncomfortable sharing, and questions were framed in a way that allowed them to speak from professional experience without revealing confidential details (British Sociological Association, 2017; Swedish Research Council, 2025). In this way, the ethical approach adopted in the study aimed to support both the integrity of the research and the protection of those contributing to it (National Commission for the Protection of Human Subjects of Biomedical and Behavioral Research, 1979; Swedish Research Council, 2025).

3.6.3. Data protection regulations

The collected personal data in this study was handled in accordance with Regulation (EU) 2016/679, commonly known as GDPR, and its ratified Swedish derivative Dataskyddsförordningen (SFS 2018:218) (European Council, 2024; Sveriges Riksdag, 2026). The collected data was only used for the purposes that were stated to the participants when consent was obtained. Once the data are no longer needed for the completion and examination of the thesis, they should be deleted or securely archived in accordance with relevant institutional requirements. Further, the researchers avoided collecting personal information that was not relevant to the aims of the study (European Data Protection Supervisor, n.d.; European Parliament and Council of the European Union, 2016).

3.6.4. Refusal of participation and Anonymity

Participation in the study was entirely voluntary, and respondents were free to decline or withdraw participation at any time without needing to provide justification (British Sociological Association, 2017; Swedish Research Council, 2025). They were also informed that they could choose not to answer specific questions during the interview.

Anonymity and confidentiality were treated with particular care in the present study, as the organisational processes and roles that the respondents discussed may make them identifiable. Therefore, the material was anonymised in the thesis through the removal or generalisation of names, company identifiers, and other details that were not necessary for the analysis (Kaiser, 2009; Wiles et al., 2008). Respondents were consequently referred to through codes or broad role descriptions rather than by their full identity, and company names were omitted where disclosure could compromise confidentiality (Bell et al., 2019, pp. 112-130; Kaiser, 2009).

The findings were therefore presented in a way that focused on patterns across stages and constructs rather than on exposing individual participants or companies. This was especially relevant because some respondents occupied visible roles in their organisations or industries. By anonymising respondents and limiting unnecessary identifying details, the study sought to protect participants while still allowing their empirical insights to inform the analysis.

4. Findings

The following chapter presents the empirical findings derived from the twelve semi-structured interviews with marketing and branding professionals. The respondents represent organisations across all three proposed stages of the Brand Personification Continuum. Guided by the five constructs developed in the methodology, the analysis is structured sequentially and stage differences are made explicit where relevant.

The analysis moves between the theoretical framework and the empirical material. Although the initial coding structure was derived from the constructs, the interpretation remained open to refinements, extensions, or challenges introduced by the respondents. Respondents are referred to using their assigned two-letter identifiers, as presented in Table 3 of the methodology.

4.1. Organisational Scale and Representational Complexity (OSRC)

The first construct examines how the number of people involved influences different dimensions of the brand experience. Across the interviews, a clear pattern emerges: as organisations grow and the number of actors involved in brand-relevant interactions increases, the structural conditions under which personification is enacted and managed also change.

4.1.1. Stage 1 - Concentration: Concentrated Scale and Minimal Representational Complexity

Across the four Stage 1 respondents, the picture that emerges points to concentration. The number of individuals actively involved in the brand experience is small, ranging from a single founder to a handful of closely connected collaborators. SK described his brand as being built almost entirely through his own activity, while MK observed that in companies at this scale, "*only* [the] *founder is a person who is value-driven*". Consequently, brand communication almost exclusively happens through that individual.

What is particularly notable about Stage 1 respondents is the degree to which the founder's presence constitutes the representational infrastructure of the brand. LA, a cryptocurrency-focused founder operating primarily through social media platforms and live-streamed content, stated that in technology-driven projects, "*public building is one of the biggest branding now*". Further, LA means that showing one's face and communicating in real time generates significantly stronger brand trust than professional-looking but impersonal approaches.

GK, a head of digital communications at an early-stage Georgian winery, reinforced this picture from a slightly different vantage point. Operating within a team of five to ten people, GK noted that while multiple individuals were nominally involved in brand-related activities, the founders and the CEO remained "*involved in everything the company does*." GK further noted that an industry-renowned external winemaker, deeply embedded in their production processes, has in a way become positioned as a face of the brand.

4.1.2. Stage 2 - Distribution: Growing Scale and Emerging Representational Complexity

The four Stage 2 respondents demonstrate a different structural condition. Organisational scale has grown to a point where the founder or CEO can no longer serve as the sole carrier of brand meaning in everyday interactions.

AA, founder and CEO of a digital media platform with a team of approximately ten people and a large social media following, described how the departure of the original team and the arrival of new employees from different professional backgrounds had created a substantial representational challenge. As he put it, "*the brand was gone"* as their tacit knowledge left with the departing team, while the new employees were not able to reliably reconstruct the brand's character from observable cues alone.

TB, the CMO of a construction development company, described a small but growing organisation in which she and the CEO together constituted the primary brand-shaping actors. Notably, she identified a tension that is structurally characteristic of Stage 2; the organisation had already outgrown purely informal brand management, but had not yet institutionalised a formal brand document or distributed governance mechanism. "*When I first got to the company, it was like nothing,*" she recounted, explaining that brand development was in active process and that most consistency was maintained through her own hands-on involvement.

AN, who serves as Product Strategy Lead at a cryptocurrency exchange, offered a detailed Stage 2 account. With a marketing team of around seven people, the organisation was large enough to have begun formalising brand processes but still small enough for the founding leadership to remain closely involved regarding key branding decisions. AN described a brand document that had existed but was "*not good enough because not the entire company could understand it*". This then prompted revisions to be more concise, personalised to each department, and anchored in the lived experience of every team member.

MG, the operations manager of a small Canadian woodworking company, represented the earliest point on the Distribution stage. With a team of approximately ten and a rebranding effort underway, MG described an organisation where the investor-founder exerted strong informal control over brand direction. As explained by MG, the team is rather small, which makes alignment relatively easy: “*I can gather eight people and explain everything very quick but if it would be* [...] *more people it* [...] *becomes difficult to control the elements*”.

As an investor acquired the company, and renamed it using his own last name as the brand name. According to MG, this was done to distance the company from the previous owner and to symbolically support the company's new direction. This placed the brand's character in direct relationship with the new investor's personal standards, expectations and reputation.

4.1.3. Stage 3 - Dispersion: Large-Scale Organisations and High Representational Complexity

The four Stage 3 respondents present a qualitatively different set of conditions. In each case, the number of individuals involved in brand-relevant interactions is structurally unmanageable through direct oversight.

AC, marketing lead at the online gambling company Spribe and its flagship product Aviator, described an organisation in which up to twenty people were directly involved in brand management activities on a daily basis. More importantly, their brand interactions extended to six thousand partner casinos worldwide, each of which made independent decisions about how to present and promote the Aviator brand to end users. "*We are so big* [...] *that it's not manageable at all,*" AC stated directly, acknowledging that the organisation could send guidelines to casino partners but could not realistically enforce them.

LS, strategic brand manager at TBC Insurance, offered a comparable illustration of Stage 3 representational complexity. With approximately 500 sales representatives operating across digital and physical channels, the brand's everyday embodiment was distributed across a workforce whose brand-relevant interactions could not be monitored in real time.

GI, commercial director at a Georgian luxury food holding, described a similar structure in which brand meaning was delivered through a chain of trained consultants, floor staff, and B2B sales representatives, each of whom had been equipped with product knowledge and brand positioning awareness in order to function as credible carriers of the brand's premium identity.

VV, co-founder of Georgia's largest digital creative agency and commercial director of the largest cryptocurrency exchange in Georgia, approached the complexity question from a governance perspective. His observation that each channel must feel "*native*" rather than copy-pasted captures a tension characteristic of Stage 3: the need for both consistency in foundational brand meaning and adaptability in how that meaning is enacted across different audience environments.

Taken together, the OSRC data shows that as organisations grow, the mechanisms required to maintain coherence shift from personal embodiment, to informal coordination and codification, to large-scale governance.

Stage	Respondents	Scale characteristic	Representational implication
Stage 1: Concentration	GK*, SK, MK, LA	1-10 people; founder-centric	Low complexity; founder is primary carrier
Stage 2: Distribution	AA, MG*, TB, AN	10-50 people; informal coordination	Growing complexity; emerging need for codification
Stage 3: Dispersion	AC, GI, VV, LS	50+ people + external networks	High complexity; governance and diagnostic tools required

Table 5: Summary of Organisational Scale and Representational Complexity across Stages

4.2. Personification Source Configuration (PSC)

The second construct addresses who or what functions as the primary human carrier of brand meaning at each stage. The findings support the continuum's proposed pattern: at Stage 1, the founder is the dominant source; at Stage 2, this centrality begins to distribute toward employees and customer-facing teams; and at Stage 3, personification sources multiply.

4.2.1. Stage 1 - Concentration: The Founder as Primary Personification Source

The Stage 1 accounts are revealing in the degree to which the founder's identity, presence, and behaviour are inseparable from the brand's character in consumers' minds. AA described a dynamic in which his own professional identity, networking style, and areas of intellectual interest had become deeply fused with the identity of his media platform. He described a deliberate brainstorming session in which the team decided to construct the brand around approximately seventy percent of his personal character, supplementing it with an additional thirty percent of strategically chosen traits that he personally lacked but the brand needed.

SK, a serial entrepreneur with a focus on technology startups, offered an equally direct articulation of this dynamic. He described an experience in which arriving to a client meeting in a different car changed the entire nature of the negotiation process. This was grounded in the physical cue of the car altering how the client perceived the brand's standing and credibility. SK also noted explicitly that "*when you are a small company, your branding is* [the] *company's branding and your brand is* [...] *how you are acting*".

The founder's role as personification source is, however, not framed as entirely unproblematic. AA observed that the conflation of founder and brand identity creates significant vulnerability, as

potential acquirers had expressed concern that the brand was too dependent on his personal identity to function independently if the company would change ownership.

LA provided a further nuance specific to digital-first entrepreneurship in the blockchain context. He described a functional division between *“meme-coin projects*”, which are community-driven and where the founder hides behind the depicted character of the coin itself, and founder-driven “*utility technology projects*”. Here, the founder's identity, public visibility, and daily communication constitute the primary brand signal.

4.2.2. Stage 2 - Distribution: Distributed Personification and the Transition Away from the Founder

Across Stage 2 respondents, a consistent pattern emerges: while the founder or CEO remains important in strategic brand decisions, everyday personification is no longer primarily mediated by that individual. Instead, it is distributed across employees, customer-facing teams, and external partners.

AA, whose company straddles the boundary between Stage 1 and Stage 2, described a pivotal transition in which a near-total turnover of the team had effectively destroyed the brand's internal coherence. New employees, arriving without prior exposure to the brand's character, were unable to infer the tacit knowledge and values that made up the backbone of the organization from observation alone. As a result, this required explicit coaching, guidelines, and feedback mechanisms before they could reliably embody the brand in their interactions.

TB described a Stage 2 organisation where personification was divided between herself as CMO, the CEO whose vision had shaped the brand's strategic direction, and the sales team who were the primary customer-facing personifiers of the brand. Crucially, she noted that the sales team operated without a formal written brand guide. Thus, personification coherence was maintained through direct proximity, informal communication, and real-time feedback rather than through codified guidelines.

AN offered the clearest evidence of a Stage 2 organisation consciously working to institutionalise its personification logic. She described a brand document under active revision that would personalise the brand's values and personality for each department. This ensured that every employee, from the product team to customer support to the company founder-manager, could see their own role reflected in the brand's story. AN described the approach as assuring that "*every person matters, every job matters, everything we do matters because we do the same thing, we serve the same purpose*".

4.2.3. Stage 3 - Dispersion: Multiple and Diffuse Personification Sources

At Stage 3, multiple and partly independent carriers of brand meaning coexist. Simultaneously, the organisation's ability to determine how the brand is perceived by any given audience is significantly constrained.

AC described a configuration in which the corporate CEO functioned as the primary personification source for industry stakeholders and B2B audiences, while the B2C brand Aviator was personified through a combination of a fictional mascot character, a portfolio of sports ambassadors, and the cultural associations generated by its partnership with the UFC. Consumers, he noted, did not think of the founder when encountering the game, they thought of "*the man who drives the plane*," the mascot character, or the UFC brand itself.

GI described a related but distinct configuration in the luxury food retail sector. Here, the founder was present but largely invisible from a public-facing perspective, functioning primarily as a visionary product curator whose personal taste standards were translated into brand character through trained consultants, floor staff, and B2B sales executives.

VV approached the question from the perspective of a manager who had been intentional about anchoring brand meaning in a simple, repeatable founding idea, the notion that his cryptocurrency platform was a "*portal to crypto*", which he described as functioning like a "*system prompt*" that could orient all brand communication without constant re-instruction.

LS reinforced this perspective from the insurance context, noting that a powerful and culturally resonant campaign slogan, the "*it is okay to make mistakes*" campaign, had become so embedded in public consciousness that people started using it in everyday speech. This effectively co-opted the brand's character into their own identity expression.

Across all three stages, the PSC data shows a shift from founder-centred to employee-distributed to multiply-diffuse personification sources.

Stage	Respondents	Scale characteristic	Source of personification
Stage 1: Concentration	GK, SK, MK, LA	Individual; founder centricity	Micro level: founder
Stage 2: Distribution	AA, MG, TB, AN	Collective co-creation	Meso level: the organization
Stage 3: Dispersion	AC, GI, VV, LS	Multifaceted Individual co-creation	Macro level: the organization and its stakeholders

Table 6: Summary of Sources of Personification across Stages

4.3. Personification Governance and Internal Alignment (PGIA)

The third construct examines how organisations attempt to make brand meaning coherent internally. The empirical material shows that governance needs change substantially across the stages: from organic founder-based alignment, to codification, to multi-layered systems, cultural embedding, and ongoing calibration.

4.3.1. Stage 1 - Concentration: Organic Alignment and the Limits of Informal Culture

In Stage 1, governance is usually informal because the founder remains close enough to all major brand-relevant decisions to shape them directly. SK described a situation where his own standards and behaviour set the brand's tone without the need for formal documentation. In his account, the founder's confidence, presentation, and direct communication with clients became the main alignment mechanism.

GK similarly described an organisation where the founders and CEO were involved in almost everything the company did. This meant that brand consistency was maintained through proximity rather than through formalised systems. For a small team, this allowed for fast decision-making and direct transmission of values.

However, the Stage 1 material also shows the limits of this arrangement. When brand meaning is concentrated in the founder, it can be powerful but fragile, since the brand has few independent mechanisms through which coherence can be maintained.

4.3.2. Stage 2 - Distribution: Formalisation and the Shift Toward Codified Governance

At Stage 2, governance becomes a more explicit concern. As new employees enter the organisation, informal founder proximity is no longer sufficient to ensure brand consistency.

AA's account demonstrates this point strongly. After the departure of the original team, new employees were unable to reproduce the brand's character because they lacked the historical and cultural context that earlier members had absorbed organically. AA’s subsequent response was to develop explicit SOPs covering tone of voice, response style, key messages, and behavioural norms, accompanied by weekly meetings, onboarding processes, and feedback sessions in which actual customer interactions were reviewed against brand standards.

AN described a similar but more formally structured process, noting that the revised brand document her team was developing was designed to ensure that every department and

individual role could identify itself within the brand's story. The insight that the brand document would fail if it did not speak meaningfully to a customer service representative in the same way it spoke to the product strategy team represents a sophisticated understanding of internal brand alignment.

TB and MG, representing organisations at the earlier end of Stage 2, both described governance situations in which codification was recognised as necessary, but not yet fully implemented. TB worked primarily through direct involvement, reviewing communications herself, briefing partner brokers in person, and holding weekly case-based meetings with the sales team. MG similarly operated through personal oversight and example-setting, while noting that the absence of a dedicated marketing professional meant that brand standards were transmitted primarily through the investor-founder's implicit standards and managerial judgment.

4.3.3. Stage 3 - Dispersion: Multi-Layered Governance and Cultural Embedding

At Stage 3, the governance challenge is of a different magnitude. With hundreds or thousands of individuals potentially involved in brand-relevant interactions, no single document or training programme can reliably produce coherent personification across all touchpoints.

LS described the most formally structured governance approach found in the sample. Their approach centres around a twelve-step brand platform that is revised every five years and operationalised through annual strategic planning cycles. These transfer the brand direction to sales heads, department leads, and individual team members via printed and video guidelines. LS also described the development of a "*brand book plus visual storytelling strategy*" designed to address the challenge of creative consistency as the organisation employed a sequence of designers, all with differing aesthetic sensibilities. The distinction he drew between consistency and coherence is analytically important: consistency concerns whether outputs look the same, while coherence concerns whether the brand "*feels the same*" across all touchpoints.

VV described a governance approach that was explicitly anti-prescriptive, built on the conviction that individual brand communicators should be trusted to translate the brand's foundational idea into their respective channel environments. The underlying governance mechanism in this approach is not a detailed guidelines document, but an organic brand story, the "*portal to crypto*" idea, that was deeply embedded in the team's understanding.

AC described the governance challenge at the extreme end of Stage 3, where the brand's market penetration was so high that governance was recognised to be practically impossible across the network of casino operators. The organisation's response was to establish internal team coherence, develop ready-to-use materials for ambassadors and partners, and rely on the brand's market dominance and legal protections to limit competitive substitution.

GI described a governance approach anchored in product curation. Rather than codifying brand behaviour mainly through guidelines, the company maintains its identity through deliberate and consistent product selection decisions. GI noted that the brand does not stock global mass-market products like *Coca-Cola* or *Heineken*, choosing instead to carry artisan alternatives that is better "*connected with* [their] *DNA*." This curatorial logic extends to staff training as well, with sales representatives sent abroad to learn how to prepare and present the products they sell.

Stage	Respondents	Scale characteristic	Governance and Internal Alignment dynamic
Stage 1: Concentration	GK*, SK, MK, LA	Founder alignment necessitates commitment	Conditional success
Stage 2: Distribution	AA, MG, TB, AN	Codification needed for successful governance	Dependent on the ability to cooperate to harmonize tacit knowledge
Stage 3: Dispersion	AC, GI, VV, LS	Holistic approach needed	Dependent on harmonization of key structural elements

Table 7: Summary of Governance and Internal Alignment across Stages

4.4. Bridge from Distribution to Dispersion (BDD)

The fourth construct addresses the transitional dynamic between Stage 2 and Stage 3, where internally managed brand personification begins to give way to externally co-created, uncontrollable, and sometimes adversarial brand meaning. Notably, Stage 1 representatives were not able to describe this notion in their interviews. Consequently, their accounts are not covered in this section.

The empirical material suggests that this transition is driven by external touchpoints, the empowerment of external actors, and co-creation dynamics that are not fully controllable by the brand itself.

4.4.1. Internal Coherence vs External Interpretation

Across Stage 2 and Stage 3 respondents, a consistent theme emerged; no matter how well-managed internal brand alignment is, external actors will generate their own interpretations of the brand.

AN described this dynamic in terms of the cryptocurrency industry's vulnerability to scam operations that impersonated her company's brand, using their visual identity and name to deceive users. Her organisation's response was to issue website warnings, attend physical events, partner with credible media organisations, and actively engage with the legal and regulatory framework.

VV described a different form of external brand interpretation. The cultural and demographic diversity of his cryptocurrency platform's audience meant that any given piece of brand communication would inevitably be interpreted through different lenses by different segments of the audience. In other words, some level of misinterpretation was a structural feature of operating at such a scale. His proposed governance response was a consistent, repeatable brand story that functions as a shared interpretive anchor.

AA described a related transitional dynamic from within Stage 2. He noted that his brand's B2B customers, who know him personally, understand the brand through the lens of his own character and values, while the broader B2C readership encounters the brand through its digital platforms and has a more generic understanding of what it represents. This split between founder-anchored brand knowledge and more diffuse platform-derived impressions is a structural precursor of the Stage 3 Dispersion condition.

4.4.2. External Co-Creation, Community, and Brand Hijacking

LS described a situation in which a former political figure had publicly commented on a TBC Insurance campaign, misattributing it to the parent bank and associating it with that bank's founder's political career. This was experienced as a brand threat; an unsolicited and inaccurate external framing of the brand's identity. While LS's response was to "*stay on the path*" and not apologise or recant, the incident illustrates how at Stage 3, a brand's perceived character is partly constructed by external actors with their own agendas.

AC's account of Aviator's scammer ecosystem represents one of the most theoretically striking findings in the dataset. He described a large and active community of copycat operators who produced fake Aviator games, counterfeit winning strategies, and fraudulent promotional content. Rather than treating this as exclusively negative, AC characterised it as "*50-50*". While some deceived users never returned to the original game, the volume of scammer-generated content did maintain high brand salience.

AN described a similar but less ambivalent case, in which scam operations that copied the exchange's identity damaged trust and required active legal, public, and educational responses. For AN, unlike AC, brand hijacking was primarily experienced as a threat to credibility and user safety.

The BDD data therefore shows that the movement from Distribution to Dispersion is also a shift in where brand meaning is produced. At Stage 2, the main challenge is still internal. At Stage 3, the challenge becomes external.

Stage	Respondents	Scale characteristic	Transitional dynamic
Stage 1: Concentration	GK, SK, MK, LA	N/A	N/A
Stage 2: Distribution	AA, MG, TB, AN	Internal co-creation	External interactions increase → more diverse interpretations
Stage 3: Dispersion	AC, GI, VV, LS	Co-creation with stakeholders	Control over the brand decreases → mitigation efforts put in place

Table 8: Summary of Transitional Dynamics bridging the latter Stages

4.5. HBA Configuration and Alignment (HBACA)

The fifth construct examines how the three categories of Human Brand Associations presented by Oklevik et al. (2020), Brand Representatives, Brand Characters, and Brand Users, manifest across the three stages of the continuum.

4.5.1. HBA1 - Brand Representatives

Brand representatives were the most consistent presence across all three stages, but their configuration and role differed substantially.

At Stage 1, the dominant representative is the founder, who functions as both internal and external representative. This was most clearly illustrated by SK's depiction of himself as the brand's primary sales representative, whose own conviction and verbal commitment to the client was decisive in securing contracts.

At Stage 2, internal and external representatives begin to diverge functionally. AA described a configuration in which his own role as “*internal representative*” had increasingly become that of

a brand guardian and cultural steward amid drastic change. Meanwhile, day-to-day external representation of the brand was performed by editors, journalists, and community managers who enacted the brand's character in their public-facing work. Similarly, AN described a comparable divergence, where the CEO functioned as the definitive internal representative, while the customer support team constituted the primary external representative cohort whose tone, responsiveness, and knowledge shaped most customers' lived experience of the brand.

At Stage 3, the internal-external representative spectrum becomes wider and more structurally complex. LS described a hierarchy that radiates from the brand manager and marketing team as internal architects of brand identity, through a training cascade to department heads and sales team leads, and ultimately to approximately 500 sales representatives whose daily customer interactions constituted the brand's primary external representative presence. AC described a configuration in which the CEO was a well-known industry figure who actively represented the corporate brand in media appearances and industry forums, while B2C customers primarily experienced the Aviator brand through its fictional mascot character and UFC association.

The data thus suggests that for all three stages, the key governance challenge around HBA1 is the management of the gap between the brand's intended representative persona and the diverse individual interpretations enacted by external-facing representatives in practice.

4.5.2. HBA 2 - Brand Characters

Brand characters are real people or fictional figures strategically associated with the brand through communication. These are present across all three stages, but their role differs considerably.

At Stage 1, brand characters are largely absent in their classical sense. Thus, no Stage 1 respondent described a mascot, endorser, or fictional figure that functioned as a consistent brand character. However, LA described a context in which his brand's meme-coin analog, where the character or concept associated with the coin functioned as a primary brand identity vehicle in the absence of a visible founder. Simultaneously, GK described having an “*Italian master winemaker*” as part of his professional field. Since this person is a highly revered actor in the wine scene, he may, with his industry credibility and semi-celebrity status, more resemble a brand character in the eyes of the consumers than his actual brand representative (HBA 1) role.

At Stage 2, brand character logic begins to emerge more clearly, typically in the form of influencer and endorser selection. AN described a careful three-interview vetting process for an influencer partnership, evaluating candidate alignment across content quality, audience demographics, value compatibility, and anticipated organic integration with the brand's communication style. MG provided a complementary account of a character association that was terminated mid-development when the influencer in question became embroiled in a personal scandal.

At Stage 3 , brand characters are the most developed and structurally significant HBA category in the sample. AC accounts Aviator's brand character portfolio, combining the proprietary mascot character of the plane pilot with a large and actively managed portfolio of sports ambassadors through their UFC partnership. Here, AC described the challenge of managing multiple active sportsmen as brand characters in terms of communication logistics, calendar management, and the constant risk of an ambassador making an uncoordinated public appearance or statement that generates negative brand associations before the marketing team can intervene. Similarly, LS described the decision to cancel a fully produced campaign because the influencer partner had made politically divisive public statements.

At Stage 3, this monitoring challenge is compounded by the number and variety of characters simultaneously associated with the brand and the speed with which public reputations can shift in digitally connected environments.

4.5.3. HBA 3 - Brand Users

Brand users refers to typical user profiles, stereotypes, and community identities associated with the brand. This is the HBA category that changes most visibly across the three stages.

At Stage 1, brand users are largely speculative or growing. The customer bases of Stage 1 organisations are usually too small and heterogeneous to have generated stable user imagery. LA was a partial exception, illustrating a self-selected community of long-term token holders whose commitment to the project's vision was strong enough to make them active advocates and contributors.

At Stage 2, brand user imagery becomes more defined, and organisations begin to make deliberate choices about who they wish to be associated with. AN described a user community that had developed organically around the brand's commitment to customer service and financial freedom. She noted that the organisation's willingness to listen and respond to user feedback had created a relationship of demonstrated responsiveness. TB described a more constricted user imagery, rooted in the premium residential buyer segment: a person seeking luxury, stability, and quality. This narrowly defined user image shaped the brand's communication choices, even in the absence of a formal brand document.

At Stage 3, brand user imagery becomes a fully developed and structurally significant dimension of brand personification, with both positive and negative implications. GI described a loyal core community of approximately ten to fifteen thousand customers who shared a "*DNA*" with the brand: wealthy, quality-oriented, exclusivity-seeking individuals who associated the brand's products with their own lifestyle identity and actively shared it within their social networks.

AC described a more ambivalent user imagery dynamic in the Aviator case. The brand's primary user profile, described as "*masculine, very dynamic, very direct, global*", was a reflection of the

actual demographics and behavioural characteristics of the player base. However, AC also described how scammer communities, by consistently deploying Aviator's visual identity and cultural associations in malicious contexts, were creating a shadow user imagery that increasingly connects the brand to gambling risk and potential fraud.

LS's account of the "*it is okay to make mistakes*" campaign provides the clearest illustration of user-driven personification in the sample. The campaign's cultural resonance was so strong that users spontaneously adopted its slogan into everyday speech, attached it to personal moments of failure or recovery, and actively sought to wear the associated merchandise. This was done because the brand's message had become a meaningful personal identity statement for them.

All in all, the HBACA construct operationalises the continuum's Stage 3 Dispersion logic most directly, but the empirical material reveals that all three HBA categories are at least partially present across all stages, with their relative salience, internal-external balance, and governance implications shifting systematically as organisations grow.

Stage	Respondents	Scale characteristic	Associative dynamic
Stage 1: Concentration	GK, SK, MK, LA	Size reflects capabilities	Partial: founder/manager often is representative and character simultaneously. Brand users not yet broadly accumulated.
Stage 2: Distribution	AA, MG, TB, AN	Capabilities reflect actions	Representation mostly internal; characters carefully integrated; user imagery more defined
Stage 3: Dispersion	AC, GI, VV, LS	Actions reflects reach	Consistently well-developed internal and external advocacy

Table 9: Summary of HBA Configuration and Alignment across Stages

4.6. Summary of Findings

The analysis of the twelve interviews generates a coherent picture of how brand personification changes as organisations move through the three stages of the proposed continuum.

First, the transition from Stage 1 to Stage 2 is driven primarily by organisational growth and team turnover, which disrupt the informal transmission mechanisms through which brand character is reproduced in small organisations. The arrival of employees who do not share the founder's contextual knowledge creates a representational gap that requires deliberate codification and alignment.

Second, the Stage 2-to-3 transition is driven by the multiplication of external touchpoints and the empowerment of external actors to co-create brand meaning. The empirical accounts of malicious appropriation, influencer alignment issues, political association, and community-generated personification illustrate the shift from internally managed to externally negotiated brand identity.

Third, the HBA framework of Oklevik et al. (2020) proves highly applicable as an analytical tool for Stage 3-level brand personification. The data also reveals that all three HBA categories are at least partially present across all stages, while the internal-external distinction introduced in the literature review is empirically supported.

Fourth, the data reveals the role of a simple, repeatable, organically shared brand narrative as a systemic alignment mechanism. Several respondents described the use of a founding idea, brand mantra, or campaign slogan as a device that could familiarise distributed brand communicators without requiring constant explicit instruction.

Lastly, the data confirms the continuum's theoretical claim that brand personification is dynamic and stage-sensitive. At every stage, respondents described brand personification as something that changes, evolves, and requires active management.

5. Discussion

The following chapter uses the empirical material presented in Chapter 5 to evaluate and extend the proposed Brand Personification Continuum. Each construct is addressed in turn and assessed against the theoretical framework established in the literature review. Where the empirical material confirms existing theory, this is noted. Where it extends, complicates, or qualifies it, this is also made clear. The aim is to move beyond description and toward a theoretically grounded explanation of how brand personification changes as organisations grow and representational complexity increases.

5.1. Organisational Scale and Representational Complexity (OSRC)

5.1.1. Stage 1

The interviewed respondents illustrate the theoretical notion found in the literature review that in smaller, younger organizations, the founder usually is the source of personification (McCarthy et al., 2023; Shi, 2019; Centeno et al., 2019; Spence & Essoussi, 2010; Yönel et al., 2026).

Consistent with Astner and Gaddefors (2025), LA's account suggests that in early ventures, the founder's personal identity becomes deeply entangled with the brand, making the distinction between person and brand practically irrelevant in the short term (cf. Centeno et al., 2019). The implication for the continuum is clear: at Stage 1, representational complexity is low not because brand representation is unimportant, but because there is only one credible and cognitively available human carrier of brand meaning.

GK's account, however, introduces a nuance. While structurally being a Stage 1 organization, there are signs that allude to a HBA-type representative logic, even if they are not formalised or systematised. This is consistent with Cohen's (2014) taxonomy of brand personification carriers, implying that even at an early organizational stage, real people functioning as brand-adjacent spokespeople can be found.

5.1.2. Stage 2

AN's account illustrates what King and Grace (2008; 2010) describe as the practical challenge of employee-based brand equity within internal branding: creating brand understanding that is sufficiently internalised to be enacted consistently without requiring constant managerial oversight.

MG's account echoes the founder-personification logic of Stage 1 while simultaneously reflecting the beginnings of distributed management characteristic of Stage 2. This suggests Stage 2 is a transitional band rather than a uniform structural condition, in which organisations

move at different speeds from informal to formal governance depending on the pace of growth and team expansion.

5.1.3. Stage 3

The Stage 3 accounts confirm the continuum's claim that at sufficient scale, representational complexity becomes structurally unmanageable through direct oversight. AC's description of six thousand partner casinos operating independently, LS's 500 sales representatives distributed across digital and physical channels, and GI's chain of trained consultants and B2B sales executives all illustrate the same structural condition: the brand's everyday embodiment is distributed across a workforce whose brand interactions cannot be monitored in real time. This is consistent with Boukis et al.'s (2021) finding that front-line employees are not a homogeneous group, which directly affects brand promise delivery. What the empirical material adds is a clearer sense of the scale at which this heterogeneity becomes ungovernable through conventional means, and the point at which organisations must shift from managing representatives directly to managing the conditions under which representatives operate (cf. Siano et al., 2022).

5.2. Personification Source Configuration (PSC)

5.2.1. Stage 1

The Stage 1 accounts are consistent with the Concentration logic in the literature review, drawing on Cohen (2014), Centeno et al. (2019), McCarthy et al. (2023), Astner and Gaddefors (2025), and Yönel et al. (2026) to describe early-stage brand personification as a real-person-anchored phenomenon. SK's observation that "when you are a small company, your branding is the company's branding and your brand is how you are acting" closely mirrors the theoretical claim that Stage 1 brand personification is embodied and concentrated rather than designed or constructed.

AA's account provides empirical support for Astner and Gaddefors' (2025) finding that early-stage personification is both powerful and fragile, while introducing a dimension not fully developed in the theoretical framework: the commercialisation implications of excessive founder-brand fusion. In AA's case, this fusion was not incidental. It was a deliberate design decision: a conscious choice to anchor approximately seventy percent of the brand's identity in his own character and supplement it with traits the brand needed but he personally lacked. This distinguishes his case from the organic overlap described by Astner and Gaddefors (2025) and Centeno et al. (2019), and suggests that intentional founder-brand anchoring is a distinct Stage 1 personification strategy.

The implication for the continuum is that Stage 1's strength carries within it also its limitation, namely the need to eventually transition to more distributed forms of brand meaning as the organisation grows or changes ownership.

LA's distinction between utility technology projects and meme-coin projects maps directly onto Cohen's (2014) reality continuum, and a parallel can be drawn with Oklevik et al.'s (2020) dimension of Brand Characters. This suggests that even within Stage 1, the dominant personification source varies by industry context, and that real-person-anchored personification is the most common but not the only configuration at this stage.

5.2.2. Stage 2

While TB and MG directly reflect the stage's dominant logic, their organizations have not yet systematically implemented alignment attempts. Instead, the two respondents demonstrate more practical approaches to internal harmonization. This highlights a characteristic feature of Stage 2 that the literature also identifies: internal brand alignment at this stage is frequently maintained through interpersonal rather than institutional mechanisms, making it increasingly fragile as the organisation grows and interpersonal proximity diminishes (King & Grace, 2008; 2010; Sirianni et al., 2013).

Similarly, AN's approach is consistent with King and Grace’s (2010) EBBE framework and the branded service encounter research of Sirianni et al. (2013), who argue that internal brand alignment improves customer-facing brand equity particularly in contexts of relative unfamiliarity. This demonstrates that Stage 2 organisations actively managing the transition from founder-centred to employee-distributed personification are engaging in the kind of institutional work the framework predicts.

Within the second stage, AA's account especially highlights the precarious position tacit knowledge has among Stage 2 organizations. AA's case mirrors the assessments of Andrews (2017) and Philipson and Kjellström (2020), as large-scale employee turnover significantly disrupted the organisational culture and its operational abilities.

5.2.3. Stage 3

AC's multi-source configuration directly instantiates the HBA framework of Oklevik et al. (2020), in which brand representatives, brand characters, and brand users operate simultaneously and independently as human association anchors. As a result, the individual consumer's angle of approach dictates their assessment of the brand (cf. Aguirre-Rodriguez, 2013; Fielden-Burns & Piquer-Píriz, 2022).

GI's dispersion of personification across a trained staff cohort is consistent with the Stage 3 claim in the literature review, which argues that corporate-scale brands increasingly depend on collective personification. It says that alignment across many service providers creates a cumulative impression of the brand's character (cf. Braxton & Lau-Gesk, 2020; Boukis et al., 2021; Zeitoun et al., 2020; Fleck et al., 2014).

VV's notion of the brand as a "*portal to crypto*" is analytically significant. In a Stage 3 environment where direct and complete oversight is impossible, having a strong and organically shared founding idea or mantra can function as an invisible governance mechanism. This reduces the cognitive load on individual communicators and enables diverse personification sources to remain aligned without explicit coordination. LS's account, in which user-driven personification extended well beyond any formal campaign lifecycle, represents the extreme end of the Stage 3 dispersion logic (in line with Siano et al., 2022 and Swaminathan et al., 2020); brand meaning is not only delivered by the organisation but actively produced and circulated by users themselves.

5.3. Personification Governance and Internal Alignment (PGIA)

5.3.1. Stage 1

Stage 1 governance is performed and narrative-based rather than codified. The founder's storytelling and consistent personal voice helps audiences imaginatively fill in the brand character when formal systems are not yet in place (cf. Huang & Mitchell, 2014; Chaudhri et al., 2022). Here, MK's observation aligns directly with Roy and Banerjee's (2025) critique of traditional brand personality models, which assess brand traits as if they were predetermined by management rather than emergent from practice. This reinforces the continuum's argument that Stage 1 personification is better analysed through founder-linked cues and narrative coherence than through imposed trait profiles.

GK's account introduces a necessary qualification here. His winery had invested in a formal brand strategy, yet the founders resisted its full implementation due to limited financial commitment and conviction. This reveals a structural vulnerability that the literature does not clearly articulate: organic Stage 1 alignment is not only informal, it is conditional. It functions when the founder is fully committed, but has no fallback mechanism when that commitment is partial. Centrality is therefore both the strength and the structural risk of Stage 1 governance.

5.3.2. Stage 2

AA's account of near-total team turnover is a clear example of the disadvantage of unformalized tacit knowledge, as illustrated by Philipson and Kjellström (2020) and Andrews (2017). The subsequent development of explicit Standard Operating Procedures, onboarding processes, and feedback mechanisms reflects King and Grace's (2010) EBBE model, in which internal brand management practices create employee-level brand outcomes that then drive customer-facing brand equity.

AN's approach to the revised brand document resonates with Sirianni et al.'s (2013) argument that employee-brand alignment must be enacted through authentic, role-specific behavioural orientation rather than through generic top-down instructions.

However, TB and MG's hands-on approach echo the Stage 1 founder-centric logic more than the Stage 2 logic of institutional alignment, reinforcing that Stage 2 is a transitional band rather than a uniform condition.

5.3.3. Stage 3

LS's distinction between consistency and coherence maps onto the Stage 3 governance challenge identified in the literature: at corporate scale, surface consistency is no longer achievable through direct oversight. Only deeper cultural coherence, what Sharma and Rahman (2022) call the emergent property of well-aligned anthropomorphic cues, can bridge the gap.

VV's anti-prescriptive approach resonates with the continuum's argument that at Stage 3, brand governance must address the causes of anthropomorphism rather than only its outputs (cf. Sharma and Rahman, 2022; Brandão & Popoli, 2023). Well-socialised founding narratives can thus function as systemic personification anchors across organisational complexity (cf. Huang & Mitchell, 2014).

AC's account presents an extreme form of the Stage 3 Dispersion logic in which commercial power substitutes for, or at least supplements, governance as a mechanism of brand protection. This raises a question the existing literature does not fully address: can structural market position, at sufficient scale, substitute for formal brand governance?

GI's account suggests that brand governance at Stage 3 does not have to operate through communication systems alone. Pricing discipline and product curation can function as governance mechanisms in their own right. This extends the existing literature's focus on internal brand alignment practices such as training, coaching, and endorsement programmes (King & Grace, 2008; 2010; Sirianni et al., 2013) by pointing toward a form of structural brand protection that is built into commercial policy itself.

5.4. Bridge from Distribution to Dispersion (BDD)

AN's response to scam operators reflects the multimodal external engagement strategy that the co-creation literature recommends for organisations navigating distributed brand meaning (Juntunen, 2025; Siano et al., 2022). This is significant for the continuum: even before reaching Stage 3, organisations begin encountering external co-creation pressures that cannot be managed through internal governance alone.

VV's response to interpretive diversity reflects Siano et al.'s (2022) argument that brands in hyperconnected environments must replace unilateral control with participatory approaches, and that the brand's role shifts from author to anchor. LS's account of a political figure publicly misattributing a campaign mirrors the same point: in hyperconnected markets, a brand can emit a message but cannot fully regulate how it is perceived, projected, or spread.

AC's account of the scammer ecosystem presents an important qualification to the existing literature. This ambivalent relationship with brand hijacking resonates with Brandão and Popoli's (2023) finding that anthropomorphism in anti-brand communities can intensify blame mechanisms. However, AC's account partially suggests otherwise: in specific competitive contexts, scammer communities can paradoxically serve as involuntary brand ambassadors, driving brand recognition and customer reach. This suggests the consequences of brand hijacking are context-dependent rather than uniformly negative.

GI's loyal customer base effectively functions as an informal but powerful brand community in line with Muñiz and O'Guinn (2001) and Swaminathan et al. (2020), illustrating that external co-creation at Stage 3 is not always adversarial. User communities can serve as self-sustaining personification engines that extend the brand's character far beyond any single communication effort.

The BDD data confirms that moving from Stage 2 to Stage 3 is not simply a matter of organisational size. What drives the transition is the point at which external actors begin generating brand meaning independently, and the organisation can no longer rely on internal alignment alone to manage it. At that point, governing the brand shifts from writing better guidelines to actively monitoring what is happening outside the organisation's direct reach.

5.5. HBA Configuration and Alignment (HBACA)

5.5.1. HBA 1 - Brand Representatives

Brand representatives, defined by Oklevik et al. (2020) as people associated with the management or production of the branded offering, are the most consistent presence across all three stages. At Stage 1, the founder's personal representative presence substitutes for institutional brand infrastructure, with no gap between internal and external representative roles. At Stage 3, AC's and LS's accounts highlight how internal and external representatives can operate in entirely separate audience ecosystems while nominally serving the same brand.

Zeitoun et al. (2020) and Fleck et al. (2014) echo especially prominently here. The empirical findings confirm that internal endorsers shape corporate brand meaning through credibility, congruity, and storytelling mechanisms, but also reveal important qualifications. AC's and LS's accounts both illustrate that external representatives reach far more customers in everyday interactions than internal spokespersons do, which makes their alignment with the brand's

values a more operationally significant governance challenge than the literature has so far emphasized.

5.5.2. HBA 2 - Brand Characters

The near-absence of brand characters in the classical sense at Stage 1 can be explained by the fact that the founder's identity is the root for many of the studied companies at this stage (cf. Spence & Essoussi, 2010; Centeno et al., 2019; McCarthy et al., 2023; Yönel et al., 2026), making a separate character vehicle largely redundant. GK's winemaker, however, occupies an interesting position on the boundary between brand representative and brand character, which may foster credibility through association in a way that neither category alone fully captures. This also illustrates that HBA category boundaries can be porous, and that certain individuals can function across categories simultaneously.

At Stage 2 and Stage 3, the data confirms the theoretical caution articulated by Fleck et al. (2014), Ki et al. (2020), and Kim and Kim (2021), demonstrating that brand character risk management is a prominent operational concern regardless of organizational scale. External characters carry their own pre-existing brand association networks, and partnering with an influencer means importing those associations, including their risks, into the brand's HBA landscape.

AC's portfolio of sports ambassadors represents the most complex brand character configuration in the data. Taken together with LS's account of a cancelled campaign, these findings support the argument that brand character selection is not merely an aesthetic or reach-maximisation decision but a strategic identity commitment. These accounts reinforce Cohen's (2014) observation that external characters pose distinct alignment risks compared to internally controlled mascots or fictional figures, and are consistent with Siano et al.'s (2022) characterisation of the contemporary uncontrollable nature of brand messages.

5.5.3. HBA 3 - Brand Users

At Stage 2, both AN's and TB's accounts are in line with Muñiz and O'Guinn (2001) and Swaminathan et al. (2020), as they show that brand communities shape the brand's user imagery and, by extension, its perceived character from the outside in (cf. Yang et al., 2023).

At Stage 3, GI's community reflects many of Muñiz and O'Guinn’s (2001) defining characteristics, including consciousness of kind, shared rituals, and moral responsibility to the brand. The company's role in reinforcing and amplifying its luxury positioning means this community acts as a living embodiment of the brand's intended user imagery. This represents a form of user-driven personification that remains outside direct brand control but is still deeply aligned with the intended identity (cf. Siano et al., 2022).

AC's account introduces a more ambivalent dynamic. The dual user imagery, with a primary user profile reinforced through sports marketing and a shadow user imagery generated by the scammer community, illustrates Brandão and Popoli's (2023) finding that anthropomorphism in

anti-brand communities can produce distinct brand-attributional dynamics. However, AC's account suggests that this does not uniformly damage the brand itself, adding a meaningful qualification to the literature's treatment of anti-brand anthropomorphism.

LS's campaign outcome directly justifies Xie et al.'s (2020) Brand User Imagery Clarity (BUIC) concept, as clear and consistently structured user associations generated self-propelled user-driven personification beyond the formal campaign lifecycle (cf. Yang et al., 2023).

Taken together, the HBACA findings confirm that while traces of all three HBA categories appear across earlier stages, the framework becomes genuinely necessary at Stage 3. At Stage 1, the personification source is concentrated enough to be understood through founder-centric logic. At Stage 2, internal alignment mechanisms can manage the growing complexity. At Stage 3, however, representatives, characters, and users operate simultaneously, independently, and often outside the organisation's direct control. This is precisely the condition Oklevik et al. (2020) designed the HBA framework to address, and the Stage 3 empirical material confirms its diagnostic value most fully at this scale.

6. Conclusions

6.1. Summary

This study set out to answer the following research question:

How does brand personification change across organisational growth stages as representational complexity increases?

Based on the empirical findings and the discussion, the final Brand Personification Continuum is presented as a diagnostic stage model rather than a fixed classification framework. The model illustrates how brand personification changes as representational complexity increases, moving from founder-centred concentration, to internally coordinated distribution, and finally to externally co-produced dispersion. The final version extends the initially proposed continuum by specifying the dominant personification source, governance logic, managerial task, and diagnostic question associated with each stage. In this way, the model offers practitioners a tool for identifying where brand personification is currently located, how it is being coordinated, and what form of governance is needed at different stages of organisational growth.



Figure 4: The Final Brand Personification Continuum Model

6.2. Theoretical Contributions

This thesis contributes by developing the Brand Personification Continuum as a stage-sensitive and diagnostic framework for understanding how brand personification changes across organisational growth stages. Rather than treating personification as a static trait inventory or a general communication tactic, the continuum explains how the sources, mechanisms, and governance of personification shift as representational complexity increases.

First, the study advances stage model research by applying stage-based logic to brand personification. Following Solli-Sæther and Gottschalk's (2010) modelling process, the thesis develops a suggested stage model grounded in literature and refines it through empirical input from twelve industry professionals across all three proposed stages. The continuum therefore provides an empirically grounded foundation for future testing and validation.

Second, the study clarifies the transition between Distribution and Dispersion. The findings suggest that the move from Stage 2 to Stage 3 is not driven by scale alone. It is triggered when external actors begin generating brand meaning independently and internal governance is no longer sufficient to contain or coordinate it. This reframes the Stage 2-to-3 transition as a qualitative shift in the nature of the personification challenge.

Third, the study refines the Human Brand Associations framework by showing that Brand Representatives, Brand Characters, and Brand Users are not only relevant at corporate scale. All three categories are at least partially present across all stages, although their importance, structure, and governance implications differ. At Stage 1, the founder often collapses several HBA roles into one person. At Stage 2, the categories begin to diverge. At Stage 3, they operate simultaneously across internal and external environments, making HBA a necessary diagnostic tool.

Fourth, the study identifies Stage 2 as a transitional band rather than a fixed condition. Some Stage 2 organisations still operate with Stage 1-like founder proximity, while others already show early signs of Stage 3 governance needs. This qualifies stage model logic by showing that stage membership should be understood as a dominant logic rather than a rigid classification.

Fifth, the thesis identifies narrative governance as an important alignment mechanism. Several respondents described the value of a simple, repeatable founding idea or brand mantra that allows distributed actors to interpret the brand without constant instruction. This suggests that brand governance is not only a matter of documents, rules, or visual consistency. It can also work through a shared story that guides decisions across channels and roles.

Finally, the study contributes to the literature on brand hijacking and co-creation by showing that external reinterpretation is context-dependent. In some cases, brand hijacking damages trust and requires legal or communicative response. In other cases, even adversarial communities can increase brand salience. This does not make hijacking desirable, but it shows that its consequences are more complex than the literature often suggests.

6.3. Managerial Implications

The continuum offers managers a practical way to diagnose how brand personification should be governed at different stages of organisational growth.

To use the continuum diagnostically, managers should assess representational complexity across two connected dimensions. The first is personification breadth, meaning the number of distinct personification types through which the brand is represented. These types may include founder communication, sales, support, marketing content, retail interaction, ambassadors, influencers, user communities, or typical user imagery. The second is personification depth, meaning the number of actors operating inside each type. A brand may have only one dominant type of personification, such as sales, but if hundreds of salespeople represent the brand across markets and channels, the governance challenge may still resemble a later-stage condition. The main diagnostic question is therefore how difficult it has become to coordinate the people and human associations through which the brand is interpreted.

Movement along the continuum increases when personification breadth grows, when personification depth grows, or when both expand at the same time. A firm with many different personification types faces complexity because the brand is enacted through multiple forms of human representation. A firm with one large personification type faces complexity because even one category can become difficult to monitor, train, and align when it contains a high number of representatives. The key parameter is controllability. When managers can still directly observe, correct, and align personification sources, the brand remains closer to Concentration or Distribution. When personification depends on many actors or large groups that cannot be fully monitored in real time, the brand moves closer to Dispersion.

For Stage 1 organisations, the main implication is to recognise the strength and risk of founder-centred personification. Founder visibility can create trust, clarity, and early legitimacy, but it can also make the brand commercially fragile if meaning depends too heavily on one person. Early-stage organisations should therefore begin documenting the founder’s values, tone, and decision logic before growth makes this knowledge harder to transfer.

For Stage 2 organisations, the key challenge is making personification teachable. As teams grow, brand meaning must move from tacit founder knowledge into onboarding, internal communication, role-specific guidance, and feedback processes. At this stage, the task is not only to create a brand document, but to make sure employees understand how the brand should be enacted in their own work.

For Stage 3 organisations, the main implication is that brand personification must be monitored as a distributed and partly co-created phenomenon. Managers should map which representatives, characters, and user groups are actively shaping the brand’s human associations. This includes internal employees, external partners, influencers, ambassadors,

customers, communities, and even hostile actors. At this stage, the brand cannot rely only on control. It also needs active interpretation, monitoring, and response.

6.4. Limitations

This study has a handful of limitations. First, the empirical material is based on twelve qualitative interviews with brand and marketing professionals. The findings are therefore more analytically generalisable, than statistically representative. As a consequence, the proposed stage model can not be fully substantiated beyond this specific scope within the empirical boundaries of this study.

Second, the study captures organisations at one point in time. Although several respondents reflected on past transitions, the study does not follow organisations longitudinally as they move from one stage to another. As a result, the continuum should be understood as a heuristic framework rather than a *fully validated* stage model.

Third, the study focuses on the managerial and organisational side of brand personification. All twelve respondents reflected on how personification is managed and enacted from within their organisations. How consumers actually perceive and respond to personification across the three stages remains an open empirical question.

Finally, stage boundaries are not absolute. Elements of different stages can coexist within the same organisation, especially in Stage 2, where organisations often combine founder-driven practices with emerging systems of codification and governance.

6.5. Future Research

Several directions follow from these limitations. Future research should examine the consumer perspective more directly, particularly how audiences at each stage perceive brand personification and whether the stage-specific mechanisms identified in this thesis affect brand equity, trust, and consumer-brand relationships.

The narrative governance mechanism identified in this study also deserves further theoretical and empirical attention. Future studies could examine whether a simple and repeatable founding idea functions as a measurable governance instrument, and under which conditions it is more effective than formal brand documentation.

Furthermore, research should also examine the context-dependent consequences of brand hijacking. The finding that malicious communities may sometimes increase brand visibility

challenges parts of the co-creation literature and should be tested across industries and brand types.

Finally, longitudinal research would substantially strengthen the continuum's empirical foundation. Tracking organisations through actual stage transitions would allow researchers to observe how founder-centred personification becomes distributed, and how distributed personification becomes dispersed. Following Solli-Sæther and Gottschalk's (2010) modelling process, the logical next steps are focus group discussions, refinement of the theoretical stage model, and later survey-based validation.

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Appendix

Appendix A: Choice of Articles

The reviewed articles were chosen in the following way. First and foremost, essentially all publications used were peer-reviewed articles or (parts of) books. Of these, a clear majority were primary sources, as we managed to find the full texts of the publications (Blumberg et al., 2025, pp. 77-79).

The publications were sourced from platforms like Scopus, ProQuest, Emerald, Science Direct, JSTOR (all with access through the JU library), supported by Google Scholar (Blumberg et al., 2025, p. 80; Daymon & Holloway, 2011, p. 43). When searching for literature, search terms like “brand personality”, “brand personification”, “brand anthropomorphism”, “organizational growth" and alike were utilized, both in their entirety and using Boolean operators (Bell et al., 2022, p. 103; Blumberg et al., 2025, pp. 83-86).

Later, when screening the academic articles, strict selection criteria were utilized (Kraus et al., 2022; Blumberg et al., 2025, pp. 87-88). First of all, the recency of the article was taken into account, in relation to its topical relevance. Then, the credibility of the journal the article was published in was assessed. This was done through looking up their journal ranking and other metrics on SCImago, which winnowed out a few publications.

To ensure that the literature review remained focused and manageable, a handful of exclusion criteria were used when selecting sources (Daymon & Holloway, 2011, p. 42; Blumberg et al., 2025, pp. 87-88). Most importantly, studies addressing topics that appeared conceptually related but did not directly contribute to the theoretical development of the review were excluded. For instance, research focusing primarily on phenomena such as brand hate, brand avoidance, or similar constructs was omitted, as these studies tend to concentrate mainly on the psychological reactions of consumers, rather than the mechanisms of brand personification from a company perspective. In addition, only articles published in English were included in order to ensure that the content could be interpreted and analysed reliably among the authors. Further, older articles (as a rule of thumb those published before 2000) were excluded unless they were considered foundational for explaining key concepts within the field. Non-peer-reviewed sources were also omitted. Finally, studies conducted in highly specific or contextually narrow settings that were deemed unlikely to contribute to the broader theoretical discussion were generally excluded in order to maintain the relevance and scope of the review.

Appendix B: Source Criticism

In academic work, it is of the utmost importance to approach the sources used with a critical perspective. To ensure a strong and well-founded theoretical basis for this research, a careful process of selecting sources and data has been carried out. To assess the credibility of sources, it is important for researchers to ask themselves questions about the source's origin, purpose, age, and content (Umeå University, 2026; Daymon & Holloway, 2011, p. 44). Researchers should also consider who is responsible for the content, whether the material has been reviewed by experts, and whether the authors are qualified within the field in question.

Appendix C: The suggested process for developing a stage model

Sourced from Solli-Sæther and Gottschalk (2010);

1. ***Suggested Stage Model****:* An initial model is developed based on insights from prior research and practitioner perspectives. This stage represents a preliminary conceptualization of how development may unfold.
2. ***Conceptual Stage Model****:* The number of stages and their defining characteristics are refined. At this stage, particular emphasis is placed on identifying the *dominant problems* associated with each stage, often supported by qualitative data such as case studies.
1. ***Theoretical Stage Model****:* The model is grounded in existing theoretical perspectives. Relevant theories are used to explain the logic underlying the stages and the transitions between them. In addition, benchmark variables, observable indicators that differentiate stages, are introduced.
2. ***Empirical Stage Model****:* The model is empirically tested, typically through surveys or other empirical research methods. This step evaluates whether the proposed stages and benchmark variables correspond to real-world organizational patterns.
3. ***Revised Stage Model****:* Based on the empirical findings, the model is refined and adjusted. This iterative process acknowledges that stage models evolve over time as new insights emerge.

Appendix D: Limitation of the continuum

To avoid conceptual drift, we define the stages in our continuum strictly by **organisational scale at the focal brand level**, not by brand age, company age, or time in market. More specifically, stage placement is based on the growth of the organisational system that must enact and coordinate the brand, including employee count, the number of people involved in marketing and communications, and the number of customer-facing touchpoints and representatives through which brand meaning is delivered. In this sense, movement across stages reflects a scaling process in which management complexity and representational dispersion increase to a point where the brand can no longer be coherently personified through the logics of the previous stage and must be understood through a new stage with its own personification dynamics. For acquired brands and corporate portfolios, the continuum is applied to the **brand at hand** rather than automatically to the parent corporation. Thus, an acquired brand like **Arc'teryx** (owned by

Amer Sport) or a sub-brand such as **Head & Shoulders** (owned by P&G) can be analysed on their own terms within the continuum, based on how their own organisation, marketing system, and touchpoints are structured. By contrast, in this thesis we distinguish such focal brands from product-level brands whose personification is primarily nested within and strongly dependent on the parent brand's identity architecture, such as **iPhone** within Apple or **Air Jordans** within Nike, where consumer perception remains fundamentally anchored to the parent brand.

Appendix E: Interview questions

Question number	Final interview question	Corresponding Construct
Q1	Approximately how many people shape or deliver the brand experience at your company? (And in what ways?)	***OSRC***
Q2	How has the brand management changed as your company has grown? (If applicable)	***OSRC***
Q3	In what ways does the founder/CEO of the company represent the brand?	***PSC***
Q4	If customers would describe the brand as a person, who or what are they most likely referring to?	***PSC***
Q5	In what ways do different customer touchpoints and stakeholder groups make the brand come across differently?	***PSC***
Q6	Do you have explicit guidelines for how the brand should sound, behave, or be personified?	***PGIA***
Q7	To what extent would you say that the people in your company have a clear and coherent understanding of the brand's intended personality? (If so, please provide examples.)	***PGIA***
Q8	How consistent is your communication across different channels?	***BDD***
Q9	How do you respond when external people or groups interpret and spread a version of the brand that you did not intend?	***BDD***
Q10	Could you illustrate the main (human) figures	***HBACA***

	or groups of people associated with the brand?	
Q10a	How many consumer to company representative touchpoints does your brand have?	***HBACA***
Q10b	How do you handle differences in how employees represent the brand without controlling every individual interaction?	***HBACA - (HBA 1)***
Q10c	How do you check whether an endorser or influencer fits the brand, and how do you manage the risks if they do not? (If applicable)	***HBACA - (HBA 2)***
Q10d	Which existing user groups or communities most notably shape the brand's image and personality?	***HBACA - (HBA 3)***
Q10e	How would you say your customers represent/personify the brand?	***HBACA - (HBA 3)***
Q11	Has it become easier or more difficult to define your brand over time? How? Which elements of the brand personality do you feel are out of your control?	***HBACA***
Q12	What would an ideal system for monitoring and recalibrating brand personification look like for this brand?	***HBACA***

Table 2: Interview questions and their corresponding constructs

While the questions in the table above show the questions that the researchers entered the interview phase with, the actual interviews also included additional follow-up questions asked in situ when clarification, elaboration, or contextualisation was needed. These supplementary questions were not part of the original guideline, but emerged naturally from the semi-structured format and were used to deepen the empirical material around themes that proved especially important during the interviews (Bell et al., 2019, pp. 437-445). In this sense, the guideline functioned as a structured point of departure, while the interviews themselves remained responsive to the development of each conversation (Kallio et al., 2016).

With that being said, the following additional follow-up questions were introduced where relevant during the interview process:

- Additional question 1: After which phase, or after what developments, would you say that a brand begins to require a coherent brand strategy?
- Additional question 2: How do you verify that your brand has grown stronger over time or gained a clearer competitive edge?

- Additional question 3: How do you translate the founder's vision into internal communication and everyday brand practice?

Other prompts of a similar kind were also used when participants introduced issues that required further specification or when the researchers needed to clarify how a certain practice operated within the participant's organisational context (Bell et al., 2019, pp. 437-445).

Appendix F: Interview questions

Pre-questions

PQ 1: Please tell us a little about yourself

> **PQ 1a**: How would you describe your workplace (location, size of company, etc.) and what your current position at the company is (roles, what it means for the company etc.).

PQ 2: Do you consent to your data being used in this study anonymously?

Organisational Scale and Representational Complexity (OSRC)

Q1: Approximately how many people shape or deliver the brand experience at your company? (And in what ways?)
Q2: How has the brand management changed as your company has grown? (If applicable)

Personification Source Configuration (PSC)

Q3: In what ways does the founder/CEO of the company represent the brand?
Q4: If customers would describe the brand as a person, who or what are they most likely referring to?
Q5: In what ways do different customer touchpoints and stakeholder groups make the brand come across differently?

Personification Governance and internal alignment (PGIA)

Q6: Do you have explicit guidelines for how the brand should sound, behave, or be personified?
Q7: To what extent would you say that the people in your company have a clear and coherent understanding of the brand's intended personality? (If so, please provide examples.)

Bridge from Distribution to Dispersion (BDD)

Q8: How consistent is your communication across different channels?
Q9: How do you respond when external people or groups interpret and spread a version of the brand that you did not intend?

HBA Configuration and Alignment (HBACA)

Q10: Could you illustrate the main (human) figures or groups of people associated with the brand?

> **10A:** How many consumer to company representative touchpoints does your brand have?
> **10B:** How do you handle differences in how employees represent the brand without controlling every individual interaction?
> **10C:** How do you check whether an endorser or influencer fits the brand, and how do you manage the risks if they do not? (If applicable)
> **10D:** Which existing user groups or communities most notably shape the brand's image and personality?
> **10E:** How would you say your customers represent/personify the brand?

Q11: Has it become easier or more difficult to define your brand over time? How? Which elements of the brand personality do you feel are out of your control?
Q12: What would an ideal system for monitoring and recalibrating brand personification look like for this brand?

Appendix G: Additional questions (AQ):

AQ 1: After which phase, or after what developments, would you say that a brand begins to require a coherent brand strategy?

AQ 2: How do you verify that your brand has grown stronger over time or gained a clearer competitive edge?

AQ 3: How do you translate the founder's vision into internal communication and everyday brand practice?

Appendix H: Step-by-step Interview guideline

Section 1: Background and Consent

The interview begins with introductory questions about the participant and their organizational context. Participants are asked to briefly describe their role, workplace characteristics (such as company size and location), and responsibilities within the organization.

- This helps establish the participant's professional background and ensures that their perspective on branding activities can be interpreted within the appropriate organizational context. The interview also includes a consent question confirming that the participant agrees to their responses being used anonymously for the purposes of this study.

Section 2: Organisational Scale and Representational Complexity (OSRC)
The second section explores how the scale of the organization influences the number of actors involved in shaping and delivering the brand experience. Participants are asked to estimate how many individuals contribute to representing the brand and in what ways this occurs. In addition, participants are asked how brand management practices may have changed as the organization has grown.

- The purpose of these questions is to understand how organizational expansion may increase the complexity of brand representation and potentially shift how brand personification is managed.

Section 3: Personification Source Configuration (PSC)
The questions in the third section aim to identify the primary sources through which the brand is personified. Participants are asked about the role of founders or CEOs in representing the brand, as well as how customers might interpret the brand if they were to describe it as a person. Additional questions examine whether different touchpoints or stakeholder groups present the brand differently.

- The goal of this section is to explore which actors or representations most strongly shape the brand's perceived "personality."

Section 4: Personification Governance and Internal Alignment (PGIA)
The fourth section focuses on internal brand governance and alignment within the organization. Participants are asked whether the company has explicit guidelines describing how the brand should behave, communicate, or be personified. Follow-up questions assess whether employees share a clear and coherent understanding of the brand's intended personality.

- These questions help reveal how organizations attempt to maintain consistency in brand representation across different employees and departments.

Section 5: Bridge from Distribution to Dispersion (BDD)
The purpose of this section is to examine how brand personification operates across multiple channels and external interpretations. Participants are asked about the consistency of communication across different platforms and how the company responds when external actors,

such as customers or online communities, interpret or spread a version of the brand that differs from the intended one.

- These questions help capture the transition from internally controlled brand messaging to more distributed and externally influenced brand meanings.

Section 6: Human Brand Association (HBA) Configuration and Alignment (HBACA)
This section investigates the different human actors and groups associated with the brand. Participants are asked to describe key figures or communities that influence the brand's image, including employees, influencers, endorsers, and user groups. Additional questions examine how companies manage multiple touchpoints, ensure that representatives align with the brand, and deal with potential inconsistencies in representation.

- The aim of this section is to understand how various human actors, as illustrated by Oklevik et al. (2020), collectively contribute to shaping the brand's perceived personality.

Section 7: Reflection and Diagnostic Evaluation
The final section invites participants to reflect on how the brand's definition and representation have evolved over time. Participants are asked whether it has become easier or more difficult to define the brand and which aspects of the brand's personality may be outside organizational control. The interview concludes with a forward-looking question asking participants to describe what an ideal system for monitoring and recalibrating brand personification might look like.

- These questions provide insights into the challenges of managing brand personification and help inform the development of the study's proposed diagnostic framework.

Application for processing of personal data in thesis work (GDPR)

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Application details
Purpose of the processing of personal data
Personal data will be gathered to build a conceptual model on how branding and brand personification changes

Which categories of personal data which will be processed? (For example: companies, students, the general public.)
Companies and their representatives in branding, communications and marketing

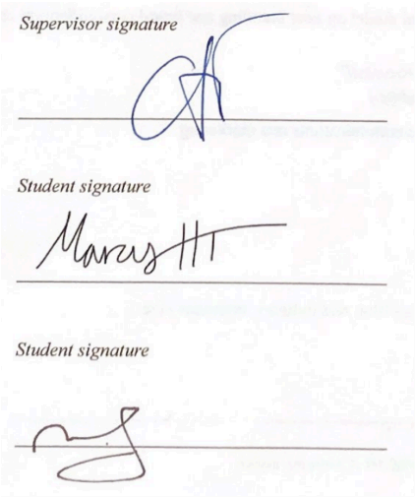
Which kind of personal data will be collected?
(For example: name, e-mail, age)

Regarding the respondent: First name and age
Regarding their company: type of company, their position and industry, company size.

How will the personal data be safely stored?
For example, in my home folder at the JU servers, on my computer.
Locally on personal computer(s) and in the JU servers

Specify if the personal data will be transferred to a third party, that is, other than JIBS. If yes, please state the organization below. Otherwise, state no.
No

By signing the form, ***the supervisor*** *certifies that the design of the thesis meets the requirements of the Data Protection Regulation. This includes that informed consent will be obtained and that sensitive personal data will not be processed.*
By signing the form, ***the student certifies*** *that the implementation of the thesis work will follow the approved framework and Jönköping International Business School's instructions. T****he student further certifies that the personal data will be deleted when the thesis work has been completed***



Participant GDPR Information Sheet

You are being invited to take part in a Master's thesis study. Before you decide whether or not to take part, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully.

The purpose of this study is to explore how companies express and manage brand personification as they grow and evolve. The research forms part of a Master's thesis and aims to contribute to a better understanding of how branding practices develop across different stages of organizational development.

Personal data will be collected through interviews with professionals who have experience working with branding, marketing, or organizational communication. The insights gathered from these interviews will help illustrate how brand personification is understood, materialized and applied in practice, thereby supporting the methodological and analytical objectives of the thesis.

The study is conducted solely for academic purposes and contributes to the researchers' learning and training in qualitative research methodology.

It is entirely up to you to decide whether or not to take part. If you decide to do so, you will be given this information sheet to keep and will be asked to give your consent. All the information that we collect about you during the course of the research will be kept strictly confidential. You will not be able to be identified in any ensuing reports or publications.

Under GDPR rules, you have the following rights over your personal data:

- ***The right to be informed*** *- You must be informed if your personal data is being used.*
- ***The right of access*** *- You can ask for a copy of your data by making a 'subject access request'.*
- ***The right to rectification*** *- You can ask for your data held to be corrected.*
- ***The right to erasure*** *- You can ask for your data to be deleted.*
- ***The right to restrict processing*** *- You can limit the way an organisation uses your personal data if you are concerned about the accuracy of the data or how it is being used.*
- ***The right to data portability*** *- You have the right to get your personal data from an organisation in a way that is accessible and machine-readable. You also have the right to ask an organisation to transfer your data to another organisation.*
- ***The right to object*** *- You have the right to object to the use of your personal data in some circumstances. You have an absolute right to object to an organisation using your data for direct marketing.*
- ***How your data is processed using automated decision making and profiling.*** *You have the right not to be subject to a decision that is based solely on automated processing if the decision affects your legal rights or other equally important matters; to understand the reasons behind decisions made about you by automated processing and the possible consequences of the decisions, and to object to profiling in certain situations, including for direct marketing purposes.*

You should also know that you may contact the data protection officer if you are unhappy about the way your data or your participation in this study are being treated at dpo@ju.se

As a participant of this study, I agree to the following points:

- *I have been provided with necessary information about the study and been given adequate time to consider my participation.*
- *I have been given the opportunity to ask questions about the study and any questions have been answered to my satisfaction.*
- *I understand that my participation in the study is voluntary.*
- *I have been given the opportunity to decide the degree of anonymity regarding personal details, such as the name of the interviewee or represented company.*
- *I understand that taking part in the study will involve me being interviewed and I agree to this interview being audio-recorded for transcription. All collected data will be treated confidentially.*
- *I have been given the opportunity to read the results of my interview, take out or adjust parts along with contributing additional statements prior to the publication of the study.*

- *I understand that the study may be published and thus accessible for future research.*
- *I understand that I have the right to withdraw from the study at any time, which consequently removes my data from the study.*

Thank you for reading this information sheet and for considering whether to take part in this research study.

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